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Study Material

Managing Conflict Peacefully: Tools and Techniques

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From the founders...



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Analyzing Conflict

What do you think of when you hear the word “conflict”? Many people associate conflict with negativity, stress, avoidance, and even violence. **But conflict can be an opportunity for transformation, learning, and deepening relationships.** Healthy conflict is a normal part of life – something we all experience as part of human interaction. Some degree of conflict is likely needed for innovation and creativity. What is not normal is being stuck in conflict so that it prevents us from thriving in our work, relationships, and communities. If conflict is holding us back, it is a sign we need to take a new approach. **Conflict can be defined as the *perceived incompatibility of interests, needs, and goals*** between two or more parties or even defined simply as any place two or more people are stuck. Perceived differences are found in families, workplaces, and communities – all the places’ humans interact. Often, conflicts occur because people make assumptions about others’ views and needs, and put their desire to be right over the value of developing trusting relationships and solving problems. The following can go a long way in effectively resolving conflict: seeing beyond stated positions to underlying interests and concerns, using a problem-solving mindset, developing communication skills, and focusing as much on relationship as issues.

What are Interests?

Interests are desires or goals--the things **that people want to achieve in a conflict situation.** Unlike people's positions. In many cases, interests link up to tangible items that people say they want, such as land, money, or jobs. For example, two people might be vying for a promotion-- both arguing that they are the better candidate (their position). But their interests could be quite different. One might want the promotion because they want an increase in salary (their interest) and the other might want the opportunity to that the higher-level position offers (a different interest).

Assuming they are both competent and deserving of the promotion, a creative boss might be able to give the promotion to the one who wants the salary increase, while increasing the travel responsibilities of the other person. This way she can satisfy both people, even though only one promotion was available.

Interests v. Positions, Needs, and Values

Many theorists contrast interests with positions. In their best-selling book, *Getting to Yes*, Roger Fisher and William Ury assert that almost all disputes have negotiable interests. But when people define their dispute in terms of positions, they often appear to be highly intractable, since one side wants something that the other completely opposes. Therefore, rather than describing a dispute in terms of parties' positions about what they want, it is often helpful to redefine the situation in terms of the reasons that underlie these positions. By focusing on underlying interests rather than overt positions, apparently resolution-resistant conflicts often become solvable. This is because, in many cases, interests are compatible, even when positions are not. Focusing on interests enables the parties to identify win-win solutions to problems that might not have been evident when the issues were described in terms of positions.

Reframing from positions to interests can even help in what appear to be quite intractable conflicts. For instance, a minority group might take the position that it wants complete independence from its current home country, while the reason that it wants independence may not actually be independence for its own sake, but rather a desire for increased political control and improved social and economic status. If those "interests" can be provided without granting independence, then a mutually agreeable solution might be found. However, parties are not always able to resolve their dispute by reconciling interests. In cases where conflicts are distributive in nature, the available resources must be divided among two or more people or groups. The more one gets, the less the others get, and there may be no way to "enlarge the pie." In such cases, attending to interests will not allow parties to generate win-win solution.

Interests and Human Needs

Other theorists discuss the relationship between interests, human needs, and values. Some suggest that human needs can be thought of as very powerful interests. But while these theorists blend the concepts of interests and needs, human needs theorists, such as **John Burton**, maintain that there is an important distinction between the two. Although both interests and needs can be thought of as underlying desires, human needs theorists argue that needs are more fundamental than interests. In addition, while interests are tangible things that can be traded or compromised, needs such as identity, security, and recognition are not compromisable.

Interests and Values

Likewise, it is important to distinguish between interests and fundamental values. There are instances in which conflict results from a clash between differing world-views. If individuals or groups have radically different ideas about the best way to live, they are likely to stress the importance of very different things and to have vastly different or incompatible goals. Like needs, values tend to be quite stable and non-negotiable. If the basic substantive issues of the conflict are deeply embedded in the participants' moral views, these issues are likely to be intractable. Any attempts to resolve such conflicts solely by addressing interests are likely to prove ineffective. Thus, human needs theorists argue, interest-based bargaining is excellent for interest-based disputes, but it should not be applied to disputes involving human needs or deep-rooted value differences. (That is why interest-based bargaining cannot resolve the environmental conflict--as the underlying interests are also fundamental values, thus are not for trading.

Types of CONFLICT

Scholars have identified different kinds or types of conflict. There can be social conflicts, intercommunity conflicts, caste conflicts, group conflict, interpersonal conflict, intellectual conflict, economic conflicts, cultural conflicts, religious conflicts, racial or ethnic conflicts, ideological conflicts, hot and cold conflict, north and south conflict, regional conflicts, international or intra-national conflicts and so on. Moreover, a study of different typologies of conflicts may provide interrelated insights into a given conflict situation. Such insights could enable an analyst and potential third-party intervener to see a conflict from various angles, thereby enhancing the likelihood of a more effective response. **Anatol Rapoport** has proposed a threefold classification of conflicts: fights, games, and debates. Their distinguishing criteria are: how the opponent is viewed, the intent of the parties, and the rational content of the situation. In a fight, the opponent is viewed as a nuisance, the intent is to harm him, and the situation is devoid of rationality. In a game, the opponent is viewed like oneself, the intent is to outwit him, and the situation is completely rational. And in a debate, the opponent is viewed as essential but of a different sort, the intent is to convince him, and the situation is presumably rational (Rapoport, 1960, p.8). **Singer's** conflict typology is based on the political status of conflict parties. He retains his original distinction between (a) interstate wars and (b) extra-systemic (mainly colonial) wars, but here adds two further classes of non-interstate conflict, (c) 'civil' conflicts, in which, unlike (b), one protagonist may be 'an insurgent or revolutionary group within the recognized territorial boundaries of the state', and (d) the 'increasingly complex intrastate wars' in former colonial states, where the challenge may come from 'culturally defined groups whose members identify with one another and with the group on the basis of shared racial, ethnic, linguistic, religious, or kinship characteristics' (Cited in Ramsbotham, et al, 2005, p.65). Many social scientists, especially sociologists, have addressed themselves to the task of developing a general classification of social conflicts throughout the 20th century.

Pitirim A Sorokin suggests a useful basis for classification of conflicts, the nature of the antagonising units. He distinguishes first between **interpersonal and intergroup antagonisms**, and then lists about twenty different kinds of groups which may be parties to intergroup conflicts. The types of groups he talks include: states, nations, nationalities, races, castes, classes, orders, and families; also religious, political, sex, economic, occupational, ethnic, ideological, ethical, artistic, scientific, philosophical, and territorial groups. **Kenneth Boulding** (1962) provides his classification of conflicts based on abstract mathematical conceptions rather than on levels of social structure. **Johan Galtung** provides a simple classification containing four types of conflict, as illustrated in the following table:

- Intrasystem conflict: Individual level
- Intersystem conflict: intrapersonal interpersonal Collective level e.g., intranational international.

To understand Galtung's classification, we should also keep in mind the meaning that he attaches to the terms "intrasystem" and "intersystem." He writes: "By an intra-system conflict... we mean a conflict that can be found in the **smallest subunits of the system**, down to the individual actor, whereas an inter-system conflict splits the system in parts, each subsystem standing for its own goal state" (Cited in Fink, p. 422). **Dennis Sandole** (2003, pp.39-40) defines but also distinguishes between three kinds of conflicts: *latent conflicts* (pre-MCPs), *manifest conflict* processes (MCPs), and *aggressive manifest conflict* processes (AMCPs). According to him, latent conflicts are conflicts that are developing, but have not yet expressed themselves in an observable manner, even for the parties themselves. MCPs are conflicts that have developed to the extent that they are observable, but have not been expressed so far in a violent manner. AMCPs are conflicts that have escalated from MCPs to a level of expression: they are not merely capable of being noticed and experienced, but are also destructive to parties, resources, and others as well. Latent conflicts are also known sometimes as non-violent conflicts.

According to some studies, there are two types of non-violent conflicts: latent conflicts and manifested conflicts. A **latent conflict** is defined as a stage in the development of a conflict where parties question existing values, issues or objectives that have a national relevance. Latent conflicts must carry some identifiable /observable signs to be recognised and noticed as such. In a latent conflict the positional differences and the clashing interests must be articulated as demands or claims. **The manifest conflict** is a stage when tensions are present but are expressed by means below the threshold of violence. Tense relations between the conflicting parties can reach a turning point enabling them to use force. Economic sanctions, e.g. are a means by which a latent conflict can be turned into a manifest. Manifest conflicts, like latent conflicts, at all stages are carried out by non-violent means and without the use of armed force. On the other hand, violent conflicts, like war, civil war, armed conflict, etc. are more destructive in which each party pursues the goal of injuring, destroying or otherwise forcibly eliminating the other.

Functional and Dysfunctional Conflict

There are many reasons for conflict in the workplace, but not all conflict is bad. Friction between employees because of differences of opinion or different perspectives is known as functional conflict and it can lead to innovation and fresh ideas. By contrast, workers involved in dysfunctional conflict in the workplace have strong differences of opinion, and instead of working through their differences, they begin to experience a breakdown in communication and growing animosity while conflict intensifies.

Characteristics of Dysfunctional Conflict

- Intense Emotions: High levels of emotional involvement.
- Rigid Positions: Stubbornness in views or solutions.
- Uncooperative Behaviour: Lack of willingness to work together
- Widespread Effects: Negative impact on team dynamics and relationships.
- Lack of Progress: Stagnation in achieving organizational goals.
- Poor Communication: Breakdown in effective dialogue.
- Increased Animosity: Actions or interventions that exacerbate conflicts.

Functional conflict encourages a healthy exchange of ideas. It motivates employees to find a solution that can lead to more creativity and improved productivity. Functional Conflict also encourages open communication and collaboration, leading to better engagement and productivity. Dysfunctional conflict has the opposite effect. Productivity and morale decline, and this can impact not just the people directly involved in the conflict but everyone around them. If this type of conflict is not resolved, it can lead to dissatisfaction, absenteeism, and staff turnover. Coworkers begin treating each other with mistrust and suspicion rather than as members of the same team. Addressing dysfunctional conflict involves identifying the underlying issues, promoting open communication, and fostering a collaborative environment to resolve disputes effectively.

Conflict Management

Conflict management involves the control, but not resolution, of a long-term or deep-rooted conflict. This is the approach taken when complete resolution seems to be impossible, yet something needs to be done. In cases of resolution-resistant or even intractable conflict, it is possible to manage the situation in ways that make it more constructive and less destructive. The goal of conflict management is to intervene in ways that make the ongoing conflict more beneficial and less damaging to all sides. For example, sending peacekeeping forces into a region enmeshed in strife may help calm the situation and limit casualties. However, peacekeeping missions will not resolve the conflict. In many cases, where deep-rooted, fundamental values and/or non-negotiable human needs are at stake, management is the most feasible step.

Conflict Resolution

Incompatible interests are not the only things at issue in more severe conflicts. Conflicts last longer and are more deeply rooted than disputes. They tend to arise over non-negotiable issues such as fundamental human needs, intolerable moral differences, or high-stakes distributional issues regarding essential resources, such as money, water, or land. To truly resolve a conflict, the solution must go beyond just satisfying the parties' interests, as occurs in dispute settlement. To end or resolve a long-term conflict, a relatively stable solution that identifies and deals with the underlying sources of the conflict must be found. This is a more difficult task than simple dispute settlement, because resolution means going beyond negotiating interests to meet all sides' basic needs, while simultaneously finding a way to respect their underlying values and identities. However, some of the same intervention processes used in dispute settlement (i.e., mediation) are also used to achieve resolution. True conflict resolution often requires a more analytical, problem-solving approach than dispute settlement. The main difference is that resolution requires identifying the causal factors behind the conflict, and finding ways to deal with them. On the other hand, settlement is simply aimed at ending a dispute as quickly and amicably as possible.

This means that it is possible to settle a dispute that exists within the context of a larger conflict, without resolving the overall conflict. This occurs when a dispute is settled, but the underlying causes of the conflict are not addressed. There are many reasons why underlying causes of conflict may not be addressed. Often, the underlying causes of conflict are embedded in the institutional structure of society. Achieving complete resolution of a conflict can require making significant socioeconomic or political changes that restructure society in a more just or inclusive way. Changing societal structures, such as the distribution of wealth in society, is a difficult thing to do and can take decades to accomplish. Thus, fully resolving conflict can be a long, laborious process. As a result, there are other conceptions of ways to deal with, but not necessarily "resolve," conflicts.

Conflict Transformation

Several conflict theorists and practitioners, including John Paul Lederach, advocate the pursuit of conflict transformation, as opposed to "conflict resolution" or "conflict management." Conflict transformation is different from the other two, Lederach asserts, because it reflects a better understanding of the nature of conflict itself. "Conflict resolution" implies that conflict is bad, and is therefore something that should be ended. It also assumes that conflict is a short-term phenomenon that can be "resolved" permanently through mediation or other intervention processes. "Conflict management" correctly assumes that conflicts are long-term processes that often cannot be quickly resolved. The problem with the notion of "management," however, is that it suggests that people can be directed or controlled as if they were physical objects. In addition, "management" suggests that the goal is the reduction or control of volatility, rather than dealing with the real source of the problem. Conflict transformation, as described by Lederach, does not suggest that we simply eliminate or control conflict, but rather that we recognize and work with its "dialectic nature." First, Lederach argues that social conflict is a natural occurrence between humans who are involved in relationships. Once conflict occurs, it changes or transforms those events, people, and relationships that created the initial conflict.

Thus, the cause-and-effect relationship goes both ways -- from the people and the relationships to the conflict and back to the people and relationships. In this sense, "conflict transformation" is a term that describes the natural process of conflict. Conflicts change relationships in predictable ways, altering communication patterns and patterns of social organization, altering images of the self and of the other.

Conflict transformation is also a prescriptive concept. **It suggests that the destructive consequences of a conflict can be modified or transformed so that self-images, relationships, and social structures improve because of conflict, instead of being harmed by it.** Usually, this involves transforming perceptions of issues, actions, and other people or groups. Conflict usually transforms perceptions by accentuating the differences between people and positions. Lederach believes that effective conflict transformation can utilize this highlighting of differences in a constructive way, and can improve mutual understanding. From the perspective of conflict transformation, intervention has been successful if each group gains a relatively accurate understanding of the other. In the end, improving understanding is the objective of conflict transformation, despite parties differing or even irreconcilable interests, values, and needs.

Conflict Handling Mechanism and Conflict Styles

When someone is confronted with a conflict situation, they usually have several concerns. One concern is whether they will be able to get what they want or need. Another is how the conflict will affect the other party and their own relationship with the other(s). A third concern is how much trouble the conflict is going to be and how much it is going to cost to lose or to prevail. Generally, people tend to balance those concerns by adopting one of five conflict styles, which are represented in the diagram below.



People who are most concerned about getting their own needs met and are minimally concerned about the relationship or the other side's needs will most likely compete. They will do whatever it takes to win, and disregard the consequences, particularly those accruing to the other side. This may bring short term gains, but it risks longer term losses, as the losers may be angry and seek to "get back" at the competitor later. People who are most concerned about the relationship and less concerned about getting their own needs met are likely to accommodate, meaning they give in, going along with whatever the other party wants. That usually preserves the relationship, although it can cause harm over the long term if "the other" loses respect for the accommodator because they are a "push over." there also is a tendency for the accommodator to get resentful of the other party over time, although it is hardly the other side's fault that the accommodator gave in. People who are mostly just afraid of conflict tend to avoid it. They might pretend that there is no conflict, or they might simply avoid the person that they conflict with. This does not get their needs met, and sometimes it fails to get the other side's needs met either, if they need something from the avoider, or they need a decision. As a result, it can easily annoy the other side (or worse), damaging the relationship. Avoiding may make sense if the conflict is silly and inconsequential and if it will be solved by simply waiting. But if the conflict involves something that matters, avoidance can cause real problems.

Feelings get pent up, the conflict simmers along until it finally gets hot enough to blow up, and then it may well destroy the relationship. When people are concerned about getting their own needs met and are concerned about the relationship, they may try to compromise. Compromise is a give-and-take approach where you give up some of what you want to allow the other side to get some of what they want (hence the picture of the knife cutting the apple in half.) This is generally seen as "fair," but it does not get people everything they wanted, and it does not improve the relationship as much as the fifth conflict style, collaboration. However, it is usually faster and easier to accomplish than is collaboration. When people are concerned about getting their own needs met and are concerned with the relationship, plus they have time and patience, they may try collaboration. Here they take the time to really understand the interests and needs of the other side, make sure the other side understands their's, and then you work together to craft a solution that meets both sides' needs as fully as possible, ideally, without making concessions. When one takes the time to do this, one's needs are usually met more fully than they are with any of the other conflict styles (except for competing), but this approach does not have the relationship downsides of competing, as collaboration usually strengthens relationships.

In their best-selling negotiation book *Getting to Yes*, Fisher, Ury, and Patton tell "the orange story," many academicians use in their teaching to explain the difference between compromise and collaboration. As the story goes, two children are standing in the kitchen, fighting over the last orange. Mom, sick of the squabbling, takes a knife, cuts the orange in half, and gives each half to each of the children. That is compromise. If, instead, she asked each child why she wanted the orange, the mom might have discovered that one child wanted to eat it, and the other wanted the rind for an art project. Voilà! Peel the orange, give the flesh to one child to eat, and the rind to the other for the art project. They both got 100% of what they wanted. That is collaboration!

Collaboration is not usually as quick or easy as that—that is just a parable that makes the point clear. It often takes a considerably long time and a great deal of creativity to figure out solutions to meet everyone's needs. But it is possible to do so much more often than is often recognized, even in situations that are generally considered to be "intractable."

- If a conflict is trivial to you, it might be best to accommodate. Why put up a fight and make the other person annoyed or angry when you don't really care what the outcome is?
- If you do want to get your needs met, but you do not want to harm the relationship or the other person, then better to compromise or collaborate. If the issue is easy to split in half and is not all that important, compromise is fine. So, if the conflict is over what to cook for dinner, agree to cook one person's choice tonight and the other's choice tomorrow. It is quick, it is fair, and everyone is satisfied.
- But if the conflict is more substantial, and involves things that really matter to you and the other side, the best option is usually collaboration. This means you need to take the time to really understand the other sides' needs and concerns, and to explain yours, so that you can work together to create a solution that meets everyone's needs, ideally without anyone having to give up anything that is important to them.
- If getting your needs met is high priority and you do not really care about the relationship or the other party, you might be able to go ahead and compete. And if you are a good competitor, you might win. This often has the advantage of being faster than collaboration (though often not faster than compromise) and you may be able to get 100% of what you want. But often that comes at the cost of a damaged relationships with the other side and the risk that they will "come back" later to "get theirs."
- If the situation is trivial and is likely to go away on its own soon, avoidance might be a sensible approach. But when you avoid conflicts that really do matter—even if only to the other side, not to you—your risk an "Old Faithful" blow up that will burn everyone involved. Therefore, accommodation, though not optimal, is usually better than avoidance for trivial issues.

Conflict resolution can be defined as the informal or formal process that two or more parties use to find a peaceful solution to their dispute. Several common cognitive and emotional traps, many of them unconscious, can exacerbate conflict and contribute to the need for conflict resolution:

- **Self-serving fairness interpretations.** Rather than deciding what is fair from a position of neutrality, we interpret what would be most fair to us, then justify this preference on the bases of fairness. For example, department heads are likely to each think they deserve the lion's share of the annual budget. Disagreements about what's fair lead to clashes.

- **Overconfidence.** We tend to be overconfident in our judgments, a tendency that leads us to unrealistic expectations. Disputants are likely to be overconfident about their odds of winning a lawsuit, for instance, an error that can lead them to shun a negotiated settlement that would save them time and money.

- **Escalation of commitment.** Whether negotiators are dealing with a labor strike, a merger, or an argument with a colleague, they are likely to irrationally escalate their commitment to their chosen course of action, long after it has proven useful. We desperately try to recoup our past investments in a dispute (such as money spent on legal fees), failing to recognize that such "sunk costs" should play no role in our decisions about the future.

- **Conflict avoidance.** Because negative emotions cause us discomfort and distress, we may try to tamp them down, hoping that our feelings will dissipate with time. In fact, conflict tends to become more entrenched, and parties have a greater need for conflict resolution when they avoid dealing with their strong emotions.

Given these and other pitfalls, how can you set up a constructive conflict resolution progression when dealing with conflict at work and other realms? Conflicts can be resolved in a variety of ways, including negotiation, mediation, arbitration, and litigation.

- **Negotiation.** In conflict resolution, you can and should draw on the same principles of collaborative negotiation that you use in dealmaking. For example, you should aim to explore the interests underlying parties' positions, such as a desire to resolve a dispute without attracting negative publicity or to repair a damaged business relationship. In

addition, determine your best alternative to a negotiated agreement, or BATNA—what you will do if you fail to reach an agreement, such as finding a new partner or filing a lawsuit. By brainstorming options and looking for tradeoffs across issues, you may be able to negotiate a satisfactory outcome to your dispute without the aid of outside parties.

- **Mediation.** In mediation, disputants enlist a trained, neutral third party to help them come to a consensus. Rather than imposing a solution, a professional mediator encourages disputants to explore the interests underlying their positions. Working with parties both together and separately, mediators seek to help them discover a resolution that is sustainable, voluntary, and nonbinding.

- **Arbitration.** In arbitration, which can resemble a court trial, a neutral third party serves as a judge who makes decisions to end the dispute. The arbitrator listens to the arguments and evidence presented by each side, then renders a binding and often confidential decision. Although disputants typically cannot appeal an arbitrator's decision, they can negotiate most aspects of the arbitration process, including whether lawyers will be present and which standards of evidence will be used.

- **Litigation.** In civil litigation, a defendant and a plaintiff face off before either a judge or a judge and jury, who weigh the evidence and make a ruling. Information presented in hearings and trials usually enters the public record. Lawyers typically dominate litigation, which often ends in a negotiated settlement during the pretrial period.

In general, it makes sense to start off less-expensive, less-formal conflict resolution procedures, such as negotiation and mediation, before making the larger commitments of money and time that arbitration and litigation often demand. Conflict-resolution training can further enhance your ability to negotiate satisfactory resolutions to your disputes.

MANAGING CONFLICT IN RELATIONSHIPS

Conflict is a normal and natural part of life. However, learning how to manage conflict in our interpersonal relationships is very important for long-term success in those relationships. This chapter is going to look at how conflict functions and provide several strategies for managing interpersonal conflict.

Interpersonal Conflict

- the conflict parties are interdependent,
- they have the perception that they seek incompatible goals or outcomes or they favor incompatible means to the same ends,
- the perceived **incompatibility** has the potential to adversely affect the relationship leaving emotional residues if not addressed, and
- there is a sense of urgency about the need to resolve the difference.

Let us look at each of these parts of interpersonal conflict separately.

People are Interdependent

According to Cahn and Abigail, “interdependence occurs when those involved in a relationship characterize it as continuous and important, making it worth the effort to maintain.” From this perspective, interpersonal conflict occurs when we are in some kind of relationship with another person. For example, it could be a relationship with a parent/guardian, a child, a coworker, a boss, a spouse, etc. In each of these interpersonal relationships, we generally see ourselves as having long-term relationships with these people that we want to succeed. Notice, though, that if you are arguing with a random person on a subway, that will not fall into this

definition because of the interdependence factor. We may have disagreements and arguments with all kinds of strangers, but those do not rise to the level of interpersonal conflicts.

People Perceive Differing Goals/Outcomes of Means to the Same Ends

An incompatible goal occurs when two people want different things. For example, imagine you and your best friend are thinking about going to the movies. They want to see a big-budget superhero film, and you are more in the mood for an independent artsy film. In this case, you have incompatible goals (movie choices). You can also have incompatible means to reach the same end. Incompatible means, in this case, “occur when we want to achieve the same goal but differ in how we should do so.” For example, you and your best friend agree on going to the same movie, but not about at which theatre you should see the film.

Conflict Can Negatively Affect the Relationship if Not Addressed

Next, interpersonal conflicts can lead to very negative outcomes if the conflicts are not managed effectively. Here are some examples of conflicts that are not managed effectively:

- One partner dominates the conflict, and the other partner caves-in.
- One partner yells or belittles the other partner.
- One partner uses half-truths or lies to get her/his/their way during the conflict.
- Both partners only want to get their way at all costs.
- One partner refuse to engage in conflict.

Some Sense of Urgency to Resolve Conflict

Lastly, there must be some sense of urgency to resolve the conflict within the relationship. The conflict gets to the point where it must receive attention, and a decision must be made or an outcome decided upon, or else. If a conflict reaches the point where it is not solved, then the conflict could become more problematic and negative if it is not dealt with urgently.

Now, some people let conflicts stir and rise over many years that can eventually boil over, but these types of conflicts when they arise generally have some other kind of underlying conflict that is causing the sudden explosion. For example, imagine your spouse has a particularly quirky habit. For the most part, you ignore this habit and may even make a joke about the habit. Finally, one day you just explode and demand the habit must change. Now, it is possible that you let this conflict build for so long that it finally explodes.

In the same way, sometimes people let irritations or underlying conflict percolate inside of them until they reach a boiling point, which leads to the eventual release of pressure in the form of a sudden, out of nowhere conflict. In this case, even though the conflict has been building for some time, the eventual desire to make this conflict known to the other person does cause an immediate sense of urgency for the conflict to be solved.

Emotions and Feelings

To start our examination of the idea of emotions and feelings and how they relate to harmony and discord in a relationship, it is important to differentiate between emotions and feelings. Emotions are our reactions to stimuli in the outside environment. Emotions, therefore, can be objectively measured by blood flow, brain activity, and nonverbal reactions to things. Feelings, on the other hand, are the responses to thoughts and interpretations given to emotions based on experiences, memory, expectations, and personality. So, there is an inherent relationship between emotions and feelings, but we do differentiate between them. It is important to understand that we are all allowed to be emotional beings. Being emotional is an inherent part of being a human. For this reason, it is important to avoid phrases like “don’t feel that way” or “they have no right to feel that way.” Again, our emotions are our emotions, and, when we negate someone else’s emotions, we are negating that person as an individual and taking away their right to emotional responses. At the same time, though, no one else can make you “feel” a specific way. They are how we interpret and cope with life. A person may

set up a context where you experience an emotion, but you are the one who is still experiencing that emotion and allowing yourself to experience that emotion. If you do not like “feeling” a specific way, then change it. We all can alter our emotions. Altering our emotional states (in a proactive way) is how we get through life. Maybe you just broke up with someone, and listening to music helps you work through the grief you are experiencing to get to a better place. For others, they need to openly communicate about how they are feeling to process and work through emotions. The worst thing a person can do is attempt to deny that the emotion exists.

Think of this like a balloon. With each breath of air you blow into the balloon, you are bottling up more emotions. Eventually, that balloon will get to a point where it cannot handle any more air in it before it explodes. Humans can be the same way with emotions when we bottle them up inside. The final breath of air in our emotional balloon does not have to be big or intense.

Emotional Awareness

Sadly, many people are just completely unaware of their own emotions. Emotional awareness, or an individual’s ability to clearly express, in words, what they are feeling and why, is an extremely important factor in effective interpersonal communication. Unfortunately, our emotional vocabulary is often quite limited. One extreme version of not having an emotional vocabulary is called alexithymia, “a general deficit in emotional vocabulary—the ability to identify emotional feelings, differentiate emotional states from physical sensations, communicate feelings to others, and process emotion in a meaningful way.” Furthermore, there are many people who can accurately differentiate emotional states but lack the actual vocabulary for a wide range of different emotions. For some people, their emotional vocabulary may consist of good, bad, angry, and fine. Learning how to communicate one’s emotions is very important for effective interpersonal relationships. First, it is important to distinguish between our emotional states and how we interpret an emotional state. For example, you can feel sad or depressed, but you really cannot feel alienated.

Your sadness and depression may lead you to perceive yourself as alienated, but alienation is a perception of one's self and not an actual emotional state. There are several evaluative terms that people ascribe themselves (usually in the process of blaming others for their feelings) that they label emotions, but which are evaluations and not emotions.

The Problem of You Statements

According to Marshall Rosenberg, the father of nonviolent communication, “You” statements ultimately are moralistic judgments where we imply the wrongness or badness of another person and the way they have behaved. When we make moralistic judgments about others, we tend to deny responsibility for our thoughts, feelings, and behaviors. Remember, when it comes to feelings, no one can “make” you feel a specific way. We choose the feelings we inhabit; we do not inhabit the feelings that choose us. When we make moralistic judgments and deny responsibility, we end up in a constant cycle of defensiveness where your individual needs are not going to be met by your relational partner. Behind every negative emotion is a need not being fulfilled, and when we start blaming others, those needs will keep getting unfilled in the process. Often this lack of need fulfillment will result in us demanding someone fulfill our need or face blame or punishment. For example, “if you go hang out with your friends tonight, I’m going to hurt myself and it will your fault.” In this simple sentence, we see someone who disapproves of another’s behaviors and threatens to blame their relational partner for the individual’s behavior. In highly volatile relationships, this constant blame cycle can become very detrimental, and no one’s needs are getting met.

However, just observing behavior and stating how you feel only gets you part of the way there because you are still not describing your need. Now, when we talk about the idea of “needing” something, we are not talking about this strictly in terms of Maslow’s Hierarchy of Needs, though those are all entirely appropriate needs.

At the same time, relational needs are generally not rewards like tangible items or money. Instead, Marshall Rosenberg categorizes basic needs that we all have falling into the categories: autonomy, celebration, play, spiritual communion, physical nurturance, integrity, and interdependence. As you can imagine, any time these needs are not being met, you will reach out to get them fulfilled. As such, when we communicate about our feelings, they are generally tied to an unmet or fulfilled need. For example, you could say, “I feel dejected when you yell at me because I need to be respected.” In this sentence, you are identifying your need, observing the behavior, and labelling the need. Notice that there is not judgment associated with identifying one’s needs.

Letting Go of Negative Thoughts

We often refer to these negative thoughts as vulture statements. Some of us have huge, gigantic vultures sitting on our shoulders every day, and we keep feeding them with all our negative thoughts. Right when that thought enters your head, you have started to feed that vulture sitting on your shoulders. Unfortunately, many of us will focus on that negative thought and keep that negative thought in our heads for a long period. It is like have a bag full of carrion, and we just keep lifting it to the vulture, who just keeps getting fatter, weighing you down more. Every time we point out a negative thought instead of harping on that thought, we take a pause and stop feeding the vulture. Do this long enough, and you will see the benefits to your self-concept. Furthermore, when we have a healthy self-concept, we also have stronger interpersonal relationships.

Positive Emotions During Conflict

Researchers have found that serious relationship problems arise when those in the relationship are unable to reach beyond the immediate conflict and include positive as well as negative emotions in their discussions. In a landmark study of newlywed couples, for example, researchers attempted to predict who would have a happy marriage versus an unhappy marriage or a divorce, based on how the newlyweds communicated with each other. Specifically, they created a stressful conflict situation for couples. The researchers then evaluated how many times the newlyweds expressed positive emotions and how many times they expressed negative emotions in talking with each other about the situation. When the marital status and happiness of each couple were evaluated over the next six years, the study found that the strongest predictor of a marriage that stayed together and was happy was the degree of positive emotions expressed during the conflict situation in the initial interview. In happy marriages, instead of always responding to anger with anger, the couples found a way to lighten the tension and to de-escalate the conflict. In long-lasting marriages, during stressful times or in the middle of conflict, couples were able to interject some positive comments and positive regard for each other. When this finding is generalized to other types of interpersonal relationships, it makes a strong case for having some positive interactions, interjecting some humor, some light-hearted fun, or some playfulness into your conversation while you are trying to resolve conflicts.

Managing Conflict at Workplace

Any scenario in which you live, work, and collaborate with others is susceptible to conflict. Because workplaces are made up of employees with different backgrounds, personalities, opinions, and daily lives, discord is bound to occur. To navigate it, it is crucial to understand why it arises and your options for resolving it.

Common reasons for workplace conflict include:

- Misunderstandings or poor communication skills
- Differing opinions, viewpoints, or personalities
- Biases or stereotypes
- Variations in learning or processing styles
- Perceptions of unfairness

Although conflict is common, many do not feel comfortable handling it—especially with colleagues. As a business leader, you will likely clash with other managers and need to help your team work through disputes.

Why Is Addressing Workplace Conflict Important?

Pretending conflict does not exist, does not make it go away. Ignoring issues can lead to missed deadlines, festering resentment, and unsuccessful initiatives. Yet, according to coaching and training firm Bravely, 53 percent of employees handle “toxic” situations by avoiding them. Worse still, averting a difficult conversation can cost an organization \$7,500 and more than seven workdays. That adds up quickly: American businesses lose \$359 billion yearly due to the impact of unresolved conflict. As a leader, you have a responsibility to foster healthy conflict resolution and create a safe, productive work environment for employees.

“Some rights, such as the right to safe working conditions or the right against sexual harassment, are fundamental to the employment relationship,” says Harvard Business School Professor Nien-hê Hsieh in the course Leadership, Ethics, and Corporate Accountability. “These rights are things that employees should be entitled to no matter what. They are often written into the law, but even when they are not, they are central to the ethical treatment of others, which involves respecting the inherent dignity and intrinsic worth of everyone.” Effectively resolving disputes as they arise benefits your employees’ well-being and your company’s financial health. The first step is learning about five conflict resolution strategies at your disposal.

5 Strategies for Conflict Resolution in the Workplace

While there are several approaches to conflict, some can be more effective than others. The **Thomas-Kilmann Conflict Model**—developed by Dr. Kenneth W. Thomas and Dr. Ralph H. Kilmann—outlines five strategies for conflict resolution:

- Avoiding
- Competing
- Accommodating
- Compromising
- Collaborating

These fall on a graph, with assertiveness on the y-axis and cooperativeness on the x-axis. In the Thomas-Kilmann model, “assertiveness” refers to the extent to which you try to reach your own goal, and “cooperativeness” is the extent to which you try to satisfy the other party’s goal. Alternatively, you can think of these axis labels as the “importance of my goal” and the “Importance of this relationship.” If your assertiveness is high, you aim to achieve your own goal. If your cooperativeness is high, you strive to help the other person reach theirs to maintain the relationship.

Here is a breakdown of the five strategies and when to use each.

1. *Avoiding*

Avoiding is a strategy best suited for situations in which the relationship's importance and goal are both low. While you are unlikely to encounter these scenarios at work, they may occur in daily life. For instance, imagine you are on a public bus and the passenger next to you is loudly playing music. You will likely never bump into that person again, and your goal of a pleasant bus ride is not extremely pressing. Avoiding conflict by ignoring the music is a valid option. In workplace conflicts—where your goals are typically important and you care about maintaining a lasting relationship with colleagues—avoidance can be detrimental.

Remember: Some situations require avoiding conflict, but you are unlikely to encounter them in the workplace.

2. *Competing*

Competing is another strategy that, while not often suited for workplace conflict, can be useful in some situations. This conflict style is for scenarios in which you place high importance on your goal and low importance on your relationships with others. It is high in assertiveness and low in cooperation. You may choose a competing style in a crisis. For instance, if someone is unconscious and people are arguing about what to do, asserting yourself and taking charge can help the person get medical attention quicker. You can also use it when standing up for yourself and in instances where you feel unsafe. In those cases, asserting yourself and reaching safety is more critical than your relationships with others. When using a competing style in situations where your relationships do matter (for instance, with a colleague), you risk impeding trust—along with collaboration, creativity, and productivity.

3. Accommodating

The third conflict resolution strategy is accommodation, in which you acquiesce to the other party's needs. Use accommodating in instances where the relationship matters more than your goal.

For example, if you pitch an idea for a future project in a meeting, and one of your colleagues says they believe it will have a negative impact, you could resolve the conflict by rescinding your original thought. This is useful if the other person is angry or hostile or you do not have a strong opinion on the matter. It immediately deescalates conflict by removing your goal from the equation. While accommodation has its place within organizational settings, question whether you use it to avoid conflict. If someone disagrees with you, simply acquiescing can snuff out opportunities for innovation and creative problem-solving. As a leader, notice whether your employees frequently fall back on accommodation. If the setting is safe, encouraging healthy debate can lead to greater collaboration.

4. Compromising

Compromising is a conflict resolution strategy in which you and the other party willingly forfeit some of your needs to reach an agreement. It is known as a “lose-lose” strategy, since neither of you achieve your full goal. This strategy works well when you care for your goal and the relationship is both moderate. You value the relationship, but not so much that you abandon your goal, like in accommodation. For example, maybe you and a peer express interest in leading an upcoming project. You could compromise by co-leading it or deciding one of you leads this one and the other the next one. Compromising requires big-picture thinking and swallowing your pride, knowing you will not get all your needs fulfilled. The benefits are that you and the other party value your relationship and make sacrifices to reach a mutually beneficial resolution.

5. Collaborating

Where compromise is a lose-lose strategy, collaboration is a win-win. In instances of collaboration, your goal and the relationship are equally important, motivating both you and the other party to work together to find an outcome that meets all needs. An example of a situation where collaboration is necessary is if one of your employees is not performing well in their role—to the point that they are negatively impacting the business. While maintaining a strong, positive relationship is important, so is finding a solution to their poor performance. Framing the conflict as a collaboration can open doors to help each other discover its cause and what you can do to improve performance and the business's health. Collaboration is ideal for most workplace conflicts. Goals are important, but so is maintaining positive relationships with co-workers. Promote collaboration whenever possible to find creative solutions to problems. If you cannot generate a win-win idea, you can always fall back on compromise.

As a leader, not only must you address your own conflicts but help your employees work through theirs. When doing so, remember your responsibilities to your employees—whether ethical, legal, or economic.

Managing Conflict from Gender Perspectives

Recognizing and Mediating Conflict Stemming from Gender Issues:

Women face unequal treatment all around the world. But asymmetry is often greatest in developing countries. In many cases, the uneven treatment is perpetuated by unequal access to formal education. When girls spend fewer years in school than boys (as they often do), they have fewer chances to succeed as a professional.

Education

Guaranteed schooling for girls is a fundamental step toward gender equality. When considering measures for improving gender equality, one should note that data from developing countries is hard to interpret and compare. According to the United Nations Development Program (UNDP), data on girls' school enrollment can be deceptive. In many developing countries, figures on schooling refer only to girls' enrollment and do not include dropouts. In other countries, dropouts are included. Either way, girls' enrollment and retention in school is a visible and measurable problem. Therefore, it can be directly addressed by appropriate public policies. There are, however, other issues affecting gender equality that are more difficult to address.

Gender Stereotypes

Gender stereotypes are one such "hidden" problem. According to the World Bank, educational books in Brazil reinforce segregation and gender stereotypes (2002). These books usually portray men as businessmen, active in public life and exercising decision-making power. Women, on the other hand, are usually pictured doing housework or being subservient to men.

Even though this problem is well known by teachers and other professionals in the educational sector, nothing has been done about it. This is probably due, at least in part, to the sexist culture prevalent in Brazil. In contrast, the same problem was recognized in Argentina, where the problem was tackled and educational books were subject to evaluation and change.

Interlinked Conflicts and Processes

Conflict researchers typically separate out different kinds of conflict: school conflicts, family conflicts, gender conflicts, development conflicts, etc. While this may be useful for clarity and academic inquiry, it may have negative side effects for those working in the practical end of the conflict resolution field where all these types of conflicts intersect. This becomes especially clear in developing countries, because those societies are undergoing change in so many domains. So, development issues have to do with public policies issues, which mix with a variety of sources of social conflict. Gender conflicts are typically a crosscutting theme. They require action at various levels and in different domains, from structural change to family dynamics. In an ideal situation, disparities should be addressed on various fronts simultaneously. When such unified action is not possible, priorities should be defined through careful analysis. What is astonishing is that the 2003 UNDP report on this goal has recognized that the issue of gender inequality is not considered in the other Millennium Development Goals. Only those goals that relate to women specifically, such as maternal health and HIV/AIDS, consider gender issues. Until this dimension is factored into all issues, progress will be hampered.

There are a variety of causes of conflict both individual and group-related that may stem from different values and perceptions, as well as a lack of agreement about priorities and needs. This topic will briefly look at how gender plays a role in shaping conflict and methods of dealing with conflict before we examine six approaches to conflict management in the workplace. We already understand that gender affects conflict, and that these dynamics surrounding conflict occur at the societal and individual levels.

Understanding the role of gender in conflict is best accomplished through an analysis of individual levels, meaning personal, self-interactive levels--relationships with others--and the societal level, meaning relationships to institutions.

We must remember that gender refers to socially and politically constructed roles, behaviors, and attributes that a given society considers most appropriate and valuable for men and women (personal and interactional), and that it simultaneously functions as a system of power, which shapes the lives, opportunities, rights, relationships, and access to resources (institutional). Despite the struggle for women's equality and the assertion (by some) that women are, in fact, equal to men, our explicit (conscious) and implicit (unconscious) biases still maintain expectations of certain societal norms.

Norms are standards or patterns of social behavior to which people may experience significant pressures to conform. Gender norms are sets of expectations about how people of each gender should behave. They are not determined by biological sex but rather are specific to cultures or societies and often to particular social groups within those societies. What may be expected behavior for a man or woman in one culture may be unacceptable in another.

Masculinity refers to anything that is associated with men and boys in any given culture, just as femininity refers to that which culturally is associated with women and girls. Ideas about what is masculine and what is feminine vary over time, as well as within and between cultures. In most societies, those attributes and behaviors seen as masculine are more socially valued than those viewed as feminine.

It is important to point out that **gender norms** are not just about the attitudes and beliefs held by individuals but are produced and perpetuated by political, economic, cultural, and social structures, including education systems, the media, religious institutions, welfare systems, and security and justice systems.

Also, gender norms often govern not only performance expectations but also conflict resolution processes in the workplace.

Although times are changing and expectations are loosening, women and men still are socialized within rigid gender expectations. Institutions such as the church, the family, and the law reproduce these biases in norms, rules, and laws, and they reinforce the differences afforded men and women politically, economically, and culturally. The institutional systems that enforce gender norms directly create dispute, sustain and escalate other conflicts, and invade all other human interactions.

At the societal level, assumptions about male superiority pervade our thought processes whether we like it or not. The life experiences on which the claims of common dominant ideologies have been founded, such as "all men are created equal," have been the experiences of men, not women, and dictates that patriarchy, a social system in which power is held by men, through cultural norms and customs that favor men and withhold opportunity from women, controls reality.

What does this mean for managing conflicts (Gender) in the workplace?

It means that restrictive **gender norms** may surface in conflicts in the ways that parties interpret and give meaning to the conflict. Researchers have found that differences in workplace disputes for men and women are based on the social construction of the workplace conditions, meaning who's in charge, how power is distributed, how communication is managed, the way that women formulate their grievances--through a formal process and through social networks--and the ways that supervisors translate them as reliable or unreliable narrators of their own experience.

Although both men and women have problems in the workplace that are associated with interpersonal relations, women report more personality conflicts than men and seem more sensitive to them. Women also experience more conflicts over gender role stereotypes and norms, finding that gender role stereotypes cause problems if the stereotype has little to do with the requirements of the job.

Women and men also differed in the ways that they talk about their conflicts.

Women talk in-depth and at length about the context of the dispute, particularly focusing on their involvement in the relationship with the other party and talk about fairness in a way that incorporated both their material interests. Women also tend to look for ways to find middle ground and allow both sides to maintain dignity. **Men tend to use more rational, linear, and legalistic language** to talk about their disputes, and focus much less on the balance of fairness than on individual responsibility and on what needs to be done to resolve the situation quickly. These differences in approaches to conflict resolution can have enormous consequences when women do not occupy positions of power and/or are not supported by the organization. In other words, there are significant problems when it comes **to navigating and negotiating conflict** in the workplace. However, all hope is not lost! Experts have agreed that one of the ways in which to deal with and resolve conflict in the workplace has to do with following a six-part approach for approaching conflict. The "6Cs" as they are termed are designed to offer options for anyone dealing with conflict, not just women.

Approach 1: Communicate. This approach is designed to help people who hold conflicting views on divisive and emotional issues come together and have a conversation. While this approach will not necessarily resolve the conflict or cause participants to change their views significantly, it does offer the possibility of opening the lines of communication and helping people see each other as people rather than enemies.

Approach 2: Circumvent. This approach advocates temporarily avoiding the conflict or finding a way around it when the situation is too volatile or the timing is bad and people need to cool off before being able to discuss the conflict in a productive manner. Sometimes avoiding the conflict is the only way around it though this approach should not be used for conflicts that involve harassment or abuse.

Approach 3: Confront. In some instances, it may be necessary to be assertive and act immediately. It may be a matter of speaking up for yourself or someone else, someone's personal safety may be at risk, or the conflict may result in someone being denied respect or basic human rights. Asking the person what their intention was or what response they hoped to get from their comments often stops the conflict immediately. Confrontation does not need to be combative to be effective.

Approach 4: Conform. There may be times when relationships are more important than the issue and smoothing over conflict may be the best short-term solution. This solution will not help resolve serious workplace conflicts, but it may give the parties time to think things over and come back later to discuss the underlying issues.

Approach 5: Compromise. This approach is designed to allow all parties to give a little and come to an agreement that will best meet the needs of all parties involved. Compromise allows everyone to have a say in creating possible solutions and when done well, it gives everyone a sense of having resolved the conflict.

Approach 6: Collaborate. This approach eliminates the need to take sides or compromise because it allows people to reach agreement by finding common ground. However, collaboration also requires creativity and "buy-in" from everyone or it will not work. Managing conflict in the workplace requires the ability to step back and look at the situation from multiple perspectives and then fashion a solution that best meets the needs of the employees involved as well as the company. Sometimes, this process is clear cut and can be resolved with a quick decision.

But other times, the process is complex and requires careful evaluation of all the options. This can become even more complex when implicit bias is at the base of the conflict and requires people in positions of power to examine the core beliefs of those in conflict before making decisions as to how to proceed. Conflict in the workplace is a difficult thing to navigate, but if we develop an understanding of how men and women's different experiences and communication styles can be mediated through a variety of approaches to conflict management, it may lead to understanding conflict differently and therefore approach conflict resolution differently.

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Managing Conflict in Communities: Building Bridges for Peace

Conflict is an inevitable aspect of social life, rooted in human diversity, competing interests, and structural inequalities. In community settings, conflict can either become a driver of transformation or a destructive force undermining social cohesion. According to Lederach (1997), sustainable peace requires addressing not only the immediate dispute but also the underlying relational and structural dimensions. Community conflict management thus moves beyond mere dispute settlement and aims at **conflict transformation**, wherein relationships, institutions, and communication patterns are reoriented towards justice and cooperation.

Empirical research suggests that nearly 70% of community development initiatives encounter setbacks due to unresolved conflicts, underscoring the urgency of effective conflict management strategies (Managing Conflict in Communities, 2024). By examining sources, escalation patterns, communication skills, mediation practices, and civic engagement, this paper highlights how communities can foster resilience and build bridges for peace.

Sources and Types of Community Conflict

Conflict arises from multiple sources, often intertwined with deeper social structures:

- **Resource Allocation:** Scarcity of land, water, housing, or public services frequently generates disputes, especially in low-resource contexts (Burton, 1990).
- **Cultural and Value Clashes:** Identity-based conflicts, rooted in ethnicity, religion, or lifestyle choices, are particularly intractable due to their connection to meaning and belonging (Avruch, 1998).
- **Communication Breakdowns:** Misinterpretation, misinformation, and lack of transparency can quickly escalate tensions.

Typologies of conflict include:

- **Interpersonal Conflicts** – between individuals, often relational.
- **Intragroup Conflicts** – within organizations, committees, or local associations.
- **Intergroup Conflicts** – between social groups, ethnic communities, or local institutions.

This classification highlights that community conflict is not simply interpersonal but structural, embedded in power asymmetries and institutional arrangements.

Conflict Escalation and Dynamics

Conflicts rarely emerge in full intensity but rather progress through discernible stages. Glasl's (1982) **Nine-Stage Escalation Model** aligns with the “disagreement–polarization–separation” progression highlighted in the source document. Warning signs such as **rumor proliferation**, **demonization of the other group**, and **formation of factions** indicate deepening divisions. A critical reflection here is that many communities lack **early-warning systems** or mechanisms for preventive dialogue, allowing minor disputes to escalate into entrenched hostilities. The example of neighbourhood disputes over park usage illustrates how absence of trust and communication accelerates fragmentation.

Communication Skills: Active Listening and Empathy

Effective communication is foundational to conflict resolution. **Active listening** techniques—paraphrasing, summarizing, clarifying—are proven to enhance mutual understanding and reduce escalation. **Empathy**, understood as recognizing and validating another's feelings, fosters trust and lowers defensiveness. Scholarly evidence supports these approaches: Gordon (1970) found active listening significantly reduces interpersonal hostility, while recent studies confirm that empathetic responses cut escalation rates by half in community mediation contexts (Fisher & Ury, 1981). However, the challenge lies in operationalizing these skills in highly polarized settings, where parties may perceive empathy as weakness or betrayal. Training community leaders, teachers, and volunteers in empathetic communication can create multiplier effects for wider peacebuilding.

Mediation and Facilitation: Constructive Dialogue

Mediation has become a cornerstone of modern community conflict management. Unlike adjudication, which imposes external solutions, mediation emphasizes **voluntariness**, **impartiality**, and **dialogue**. The standard mediation process includes:

1. Introductions and Ground Rules

2. **Narrative Sharing and Storytelling**
3. **Issue Identification**
4. **Brainstorming Options**
5. **Agreement on Solutions**

The example of homeowners and their association illustrates how structured dialogue generates creative, mutually acceptable outcomes. Academic scholarship (Moore, 2014) confirms that mediation is particularly effective in relational disputes where ongoing interaction is unavoidable. Yet, mediation also faces limitations: mediators must balance neutrality with cultural sensitivity, and outcomes may remain fragile if structural injustices (e.g., land tenure inequalities) remain unaddressed.

Collaborative Problem-Solving: Toward Win-Win Outcomes

Borrowing from principled negotiation theory (Fisher, Ury & Patton, 2011), collaborative problem-solving emphasizes interests over positions. The stages—problem definition, option generation, evaluation, and agreement—mirror this approach.

Compromise and accommodation may resolve immediate disputes but risk leaving underlying tensions unaddressed. Hence, long-term community peacebuilding must integrate collaborative processes with **capacity-building** and **structural reforms**.

Prevention and Community Resilience

Conflict prevention requires proactive measures that strengthen the social fabric. Strategies include:

- **Building Social Bonds** through collective activities, rituals, and volunteerism.
- **Institutionalizing Inclusivity**, ensuring marginalized voices are represented in governance.
- **Establishing Transparent Communication Channels** that counter misinformation and rumor-spreading. Resilience theory (Ungar, 2012) suggests that communities with strong relational ties and inclusive institutions are less likely to relapse into conflict. However, inclusivity often challenges entrenched elites, making political will and civic pressure critical for sustaining reforms.

Civil Society and Civic Engagement

Civil society actors—NGOs, grassroots organizations, faith-based groups—play a pivotal role in conflict prevention. Their contributions include:

- **Promoting Tolerance and Multiculturalism:** e.g., Canadian multicultural education (Jedwab, 2016).
- **Encouraging Lawfulness and Nonviolence:** e.g., South African post-apartheid civic forums reducing protest violence (Gibson, 2004).
- **Enhancing Participation and Transparency:** e.g., *Gram Sabhas* in Kerala resolving land-use conflicts through deliberative democracy (Heller, 2001).
- **Transforming Civic Culture:** e.g., Bogotá's *Cultura Ciudadana* campaigns (Mockus, 2001).

From a critical standpoint, civil society initiatives may risk co-optation by political interests or face legitimacy deficits if perceived as donor-driven. Nevertheless, they remain crucial for bridging the gap between state authority and community agency.

Conclusion

Community conflict management is both an art and a science. While skills such as active listening, empathy, mediation, and collaborative problem-solving provide practical tools, broader structural and cultural dimensions must also be addressed. Civic engagement and the role of civil society underscore the importance of democratization, transparency, and inclusivity.

In essence, managing conflict in communities is not solely about **resolving disputes** but about **transforming relationships and structures** to create just, equitable, and resilient societies. As Galtung (1996) reminds us, the goal of peacebuilding is not merely the absence of conflict but the presence of positive peace—social justice, equity, and cooperative coexistence.

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Democracy: Meaning, Principles and Values

Democracy represents a social and political system in which authority is distributed among individuals in a manner that emphasizes equality. However, in large and complex societies, the direct involvement of all citizens in governance becomes practically unfeasible. Consequently, democratic structures rely on representative mechanisms, whereby political authority is delegated to elected representatives through the process of direct suffrage. The concept of “pure” democracy remains rare, as the practical realization of inclusivity often leads to the exclusion of certain segments of the population. Within democratic frameworks, citizens exercise their right to vote to elect leaders, who are entrusted to articulate and safeguard their interests in deliberative and decision-making forums, typically convened in central legislative institutions such as parliaments.

In India, the democratic model has evolved significantly since independence. While references to ancient traditions, such as the ideal of *Ram Rajya*, suggest the presence of democratic values, the institutional form of political democracy in the modern sense was absent in precolonial India. In contemporary practice, political leaders operate primarily through organized parties, contesting elections based on party manifestos rather than strictly issue-based public mandates. As a result, political parties function as autonomous centers of power and influence within the democratic system. In the 21st century, it is widely accepted that the effective representation of citizens’ interests is generally mediated through a limited number of political parties, often two or three dominant ones. The vitality of democratic governance depends on several political processes, including electoral participation, political socialization, and civic engagement. Essential features of a genuine democracy include:

- Free and fair elections
- Availability of authentic political choices
- Genuine authority vested in the legislature
- Separation of powers among executive, judiciary, and legislature

- Protection of civil rights and liberties
- Equality before the law and adherence to the rule of law
- Competitive inter-party politics
- Effective representation of diverse social interests
- A free and responsible press
- Safeguarding of personal freedoms, including freedoms of speech, religion, association, and peaceful assembly

Thus, while democracy is premised on the principle of majority rule, the protection of minority rights constitutes a fundamental safeguard. Other core elements include legal equality, protection against arbitrary detention, and the institutionalization of accountability. Despite broad agreement on these principles, debates persist concerning their precise interpretation, scope, and practical realization. Political sociologists, therefore, continue to examine issues such as the role of the state, processes of political socialization, electoral behavior, the relationship between democracy and economic structures, and the dynamics of public opinion and its manipulation.

Conceptual Foundations of Democracy

Etymologically, democracy derives from the Greek terms *demos* (people) and *kratia* (rule), first used in the fifth century BCE to describe the political institutions of Greek city-states, particularly Athens. At its core, democracy signifies governance by the people, whether directly or through elected representatives. In the classical Greek understanding, democracy implied collective self-governance, wherein all citizens or eligible members participated in decision-making.

The essential principles of democracy include freedom of assembly, freedom of speech, inclusivity, political equality, consent of the governed, universal suffrage, protection of life and liberty, and respect for minority rights. Democracy, therefore, extends beyond the mechanics of government formation; it encompasses the right of citizens to shape, supervise, and, when necessary, remove their governing authorities. These rights are exercised not only through periodic elections but also through other avenues of public engagement, such as a free press and civil society initiatives.

In sum, democracy embodies both a system of governance and a moral-political ethos. It signifies a form of rule where sovereignty ultimately resides with the people, who retain the authority to determine the structure, accountability, and legitimacy of their government.

Basic Principles of Democracy

The following constitute the essential principles or prerequisites that must be understood and addressed before conceptualizing or practicing democracy:

1. Liberty:

Democracy is grounded in the ideals of liberty and equality, where individuals are assured broad freedoms and fair treatment. A distinguishing feature of democracy is its encouragement of dissent and constructive criticism. For example, in the United Kingdom, the government financially supports the Leader of the Opposition, who is also consulted by the Prime Minister during times of national crisis. Similarly, in India, former Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri sought the counsel of opposition leaders prior to initiating talks with President Ayub Khan of Pakistan in Tashkent on January 5, 1966. In contrast, alternative systems such as monarchy, dictatorship, aristocracy, and oligarchy generally exclude both citizens and opposition groups from significant decision-making processes.

2. Equality:

Democracy emphasizes equality by ensuring that no individual faces discrimination on the grounds of caste, creed, religion, or social status. India, for instance, abolished untouchability and enshrined the principle of equality before the law while abolishing privileged classes. Achieving political, economic, and social equality is vital for the success of democracy. Provisions such as universal adult franchise, which enables all citizens to participate in elections for state assemblies and the Lok Sabha, exemplify this commitment. Other democracies- including England, Japan, France, Belgium, the Netherlands, Denmark, Sweden, Norway, West Germany, the United States, and Italy- likewise strive to uphold social and political equality. Yet, political and social equality alone remain insufficient in the absence of economic equality. Recognizing this, the Indian National Congress, during its Bhubaneswar Session in January 1964, resolved to

pursue socialism by democratic means. Contemporary efforts continue to realize this goal.

3. **Fraternity:**

The effective functioning of democracy requires an atmosphere of peace and social harmony. In the absence of such conditions, democracy encounters formidable obstacles. To this end, in 1954, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru introduced the *Panchsheel* principles to advocate peaceful coexistence in international relations. India, along with other democratic states, continues to prioritize world peace, a commitment further reflected in India's leadership role within the Non-Aligned Movement.

4. **People as the Ultimate Source of Sovereignty:** A defining principle of democracy is that sovereignty rests with the people, who delegate authority to the government. This principle is sustained through regular, periodic elections. For example, general elections are conducted every five years in India and the United Kingdom, and every four years in the United States, thereby reaffirming the people's ultimate authority.

5. **Fundamental Rights of Citizens:** Democracies guarantee individuals certain inalienable rights to foster their overall development and safeguard human dignity. These rights are enshrined in the constitutions of nations such as India, Japan, the United States, France, and Italy. In the United Kingdom, fundamental rights and liberties are upheld through instruments such as the Rule of Law, historical charters, acts of Parliament, and judicial precedents, which evolve to meet the needs of society.

6. **Independent Judiciary:** The judiciary serves as the guardian of fundamental rights in democratic systems. In India, the Supreme Court and the High Courts uphold constitutional provisions and ensure the protection of individual liberties. Where judicial independence is compromised, the safeguarding of fundamental rights becomes uncertain and fragile.

7. **The State as a Means and the People as the End:** A central democratic principle is that the state exists to serve the people, rather than the reverse. In democracy, individuals are regarded as the ultimate beneficiaries, with the state functioning as the instrument to promote their welfare. In contrast, authoritarian or oligarchic systems often disregard individual freedoms and prioritize state interests over those of the people.

8. **Welfare Orientation of the State:** Democracy inherently seeks to function as a welfare state, prioritizing the well-being of the entire population rather than advancing the interests of select classes. It strives to ensure social justice, equitable distribution of resources, and the collective good of all citizens.

Democracy and Conflict Resolution

Democracy, at its essence, is not merely a political system but a way of organizing human coexistence in diverse societies. It recognizes that people—coming from different cultures, religions, classes, and experiences—will naturally hold competing interests. Conflict, therefore, is not treated as a disruption but as a normal expression of social diversity. What distinguishes democracy from authoritarian systems is its insistence that conflicts be resolved through dialogue, negotiation, and institutional processes rather than coercion or violence.

One of democracy's greatest strengths in conflict resolution lies in its ability to create space for dialogue. Elections, parliamentary debates, and public consultations allow citizens to voice their concerns. For example, in India, linguistic and cultural demands often find expression through political processes. The creation of new states such as Telangana or linguistic recognition of regional identities were not achieved through civil war but through democratic negotiation, protests, and eventually policy decisions. Democracy thus transforms the energy of conflict into a platform for bargaining and compromise. Equally important is the protection of minority rights. While majority rule is the central logic of democracy, its moral strength comes from ensuring that minorities are not silenced. Constitutions and independent judiciaries play a key role here. South Africa offers a powerful example: after decades of apartheid, democracy was deliberately designed to safeguard minority protections. Nelson Mandela's leadership, coupled with inclusive democratic institutions, ensured that the country could transition from violent racial conflict to a political order based on equality, forgiveness, and reconciliation. The Truth and Reconciliation Commission demonstrated how democratic processes could heal deep wounds by acknowledging pain, giving victims a voice, and encouraging accountability without seeking revenge.

Democracy also works best when it decentralizes power, enabling people to resolve disputes close to home. In rural India, the *Panchayati Raj* system allows villagers to

gather in local assemblies to debate, negotiate, and settle disputes. For many, this form of participatory democracy feels more personal and meaningful than distant national institutions. It ensures that conflict does not escalate because people feel heard at the grassroots level. Civil society and political parties are equally vital actors in democratic conflict resolution. Political parties, despite their flaws, provide platforms for competing interests to be represented in the formal political system rather than on the streets. Meanwhile, civil society organizations and the media often act as mediators, watchdogs, and advocates. The Northern Ireland conflict illustrates this: decades of sectarian violence between Catholics and Protestants found resolution through the Good Friday Agreement of 1998, which was built on negotiations involving political leaders, civil society actors, and international mediators. The agreement institutionalized power-sharing and gave both communities a sense of representation. For ordinary citizens, this meant an end to everyday fear and a chance to rebuild fractured relationships. The strength of democracy lies in its adaptability. It is not a perfect system—indeed, it often appears slow, noisy, and messy. Public protests, strikes, and heated parliamentary debates may seem chaotic, but they are expressions of citizens seeking justice within the democratic framework rather than resorting to violence. For example, India’s Right to Information (RTI) movement began with grassroots struggles led by rural communities demanding accountability. Instead of turning violent, the democratic system responded by enacting a law in 2005 that gave citizens the legal right to demand transparency. This showed how conflicts between citizens and the state can be peacefully transformed into progressive reforms.

At the international level, democracies also tend to be more peaceful in their external relations. The democratic peace theory suggests that democracies rarely go to war with one another because their leaders are accountable to citizens who bear the costs of conflict. Countries like Norway and Sweden, with strong democratic traditions, have played constructive roles in mediating international disputes, further demonstrating how democratic values extend beyond national boundaries into global peacebuilding efforts. Of course, democracy is not without challenges. When economic inequalities widen, when populism polarizes society, or when misinformation manipulates public opinion, democratic systems can struggle to resolve conflicts fairly. Yet democracy has a built-in capacity for self-correction—through elections, judicial review, media scrutiny, and civic

activism. Citizens, as ultimate sovereigns, retain the power to reform the system when it falters.

Ultimately, democracy and conflict resolution are deeply human endeavors. Democracy acknowledges that people will disagree, sometimes passionately, but it insists that even in disagreement, dialogue must prevail over violence. From South Africa's reconciliation to Northern Ireland's power-sharing, from India's grassroots governance to global mediation efforts, democracy proves that societies can face their deepest divisions without losing their humanity. Its greatest promise is not the absence of conflict, but the assurance that conflict can be addressed with dignity, fairness, and hope for a common future.

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Human Rights

What are human rights?

Human rights are rights we have simply because we exist as human beings - they are not granted by any state. These universal rights are inherent to us all, regardless of nationality, sex, national or ethnic origin, color, religion, language, or any other status. They range from the most fundamental - the right to life - to those that make life worth living, such as the rights to food, education, work, health, and liberty.

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR), adopted by the UN General Assembly in 1948, was the first legal document to set out the fundamental human rights to be universally protected. The UDHR, which turns 75 on 10 December 2023, continues to be the foundation of all international human rights law. Its 30 articles provide the principles and building blocks of current and future human rights conventions, treaties and other legal instruments. The UDHR, together with the 2 covenants - the International Covenant for Civil and Political Rights, and the International Covenant for Economic, Social and Cultural Rights - make up the International Bill of Rights.

Universal and inalienable

The principle of universality of human rights is the cornerstone of international human rights law. This means that we are all equally entitled to our human rights. This principle, as first emphasized in the UDHR, is repeated in many international human rights conventions, declarations, and resolutions.

Human rights are inalienable. They should not be taken away, except in specific situations and according to due process. For example, the right to liberty may be restricted if a person is found guilty of a crime by a court of law.

Indivisible and interdependent

All human rights are indivisible and interdependent. This means that one set of rights cannot be enjoyed fully without the other. For example, making progress in civil and political rights makes it easier to exercise economic, social and cultural rights. Similarly, violating economic, social and cultural rights can negatively affect many other rights.

Equal and non-discriminatory

Article 1 of the UDHR states: “All human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights.” Freedom from discrimination, set out in Article 2, is what ensures this equality. Non-discrimination cuts across all international human rights law. This principle is present in all major human rights treaties. It also provides the central theme of 2 core instruments: the International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination, and the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women.

Both rights and obligations

All States have ratified at least 1 of the 9 core human rights treaties, as well as 1 of the 9 optional protocols. Eighty per cent of States have ratified 4 or more. This means that States have obligations and duties under international law to respect, protect and fulfill human rights.

- The obligation to respect means that States must refrain from interfering with or curtailing the enjoyment of human rights.
 - The obligation to protect requires States to protect individuals and groups against human rights abuses.
 - The obligation to fulfill means that States must take positive action to facilitate the enjoyment of basic human rights.

Meanwhile, as individuals, while we are entitled to our human rights – but, we should also respect and stand up for the human rights of others.

Universal Declaration of Human Rights

The power of the Universal Declaration is the power of ideas to change the world. It inspires us to continue working to ensure all people can gain freedom, equality, and dignity.

Preamble

Whereas recognition of the inherent dignity and of the equal and inalienable rights of all members of the human family is the foundation of freedom, justice, and peace in the

world, Whereas disregard and contempt for human rights have resulted in barbarous acts which have outraged the conscience of mankind, and the advent of a world in which human beings shall enjoy freedom of speech and belief and freedom from fear and want has been proclaimed as the highest aspiration of the common people,

Article 1: Free and equal

- All human beings are born free and equal and should be treated the same way.
- All human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights. They are endowed with reason and conscience and should act towards one another in a spirit of brotherhood.

Article 2: Freedom from discrimination

Everyone can claim their rights regardless of sex, race, language, religion, social standing, etc. Everyone is entitled to all the rights and freedoms set forth in this Declaration, without distinction of any kind, such as race, colour, sex, language, religion, political or other opinion, national or social origin, property, birth, or other status. Furthermore, no distinction shall be made based on the political, jurisdictional, or international status of the country or territory to which a person belongs, whether it be independent, trust, non-self-governing or under any other limitation of sovereignty.

Article 3: Right to life

- Everyone has the right to life and to live in freedom and safety.
- Everyone has the right to life, liberty, and security of person.

Article 4: Freedom from slavery

- No one has the right to treat you as a slave nor should you enslave anyone.
- No one shall be held in slavery or servitude; slavery and the slave trade shall be prohibited in all their forms.

Article 5: Freedom from torture

- No one has the right to torture you.

- No one shall be subjected to torture or to cruel, inhuman or degrading treatment or punishment.

Article 6: Right to recognition before the law

- You should be legally protected in the same way everywhere like anyone else.
- Everyone has the right to recognition everywhere as a person before the law.

Article 7: Right to equality before the law

The law is the same for everyone and should be applied in the same manner to all. All are equal before the law and are entitled without any discrimination to equal protection of the law. All are entitled to equal protection against any discrimination in violation of this Declaration and against any incitement to such discrimination.

Article 8: Access to justice

You have the right to obtain legal help and access the justice system when your rights are not respected. Everyone has the right to an effective remedy by the competent national tribunals for acts violating the fundamental rights granted him by the constitution or by law.

Article 9: Freedom from arbitrary detention

No one can arrest or detain you arbitrarily, or send you away from your country unjustly. No one shall be subjected to arbitrary arrest, detention, or exile.

Article 10: Right to a fair trial

Trials should be public and tried in a fair manner by an impartial and independent tribunal. Everyone is entitled in full equality to a fair and public hearing by an independent and impartial tribunal, in the determination of his rights and obligations and of any criminal charge against him.

Article 11: Presumption of innocence

You are considered innocent until it can be proved you are guilty according to law. If accused of a crime you have the right to a defence. Everyone charged with a penal offence has the right to be presumed innocent until proved guilty according to law in a

public trial at which he has had all the guarantees necessary for his defence. No one shall be held guilty of any penal offence on account of any act or omission which did not constitute a penal offence, under national or international law, at the time when it was committed. Nor shall a heavier penalty be imposed than the one that was applicable at the time the penal offence was committed.

Article 12: Right to privacy

You have the right to protection if someone tried to harm your good name, enter your home without permission or interfere with your correspondence. No one shall be subjected to arbitrary interference with his privacy, family, home, or correspondence, nor to attacks upon his honour and reputation. Everyone has the right to the protection of the law against such interference or attacks.

Article 13: Freedom of movement

You have the right to leave or move within your own country and you should be able to return.

1- Everyone has the right to freedom of movement and residence within the borders of each State.

2- Everyone has the right to leave any country, including his own, and to return to his country.

Article 14: Right to asylum

If you are persecuted at home, you have the right to seek protection in another country.

1- Everyone has the right to seek and to enjoy in other countries asylum from persecution.

2- This right may not be invoked in the case of prosecutions genuinely arising from non-political crimes or from acts contrary to the purposes and principles of the United Nations.

Article 15: Right to nationality

You have the right to belong to a country and have a nationality.

1- Everyone has the right to a nationality.

2- No one shall be arbitrarily deprived of his nationality nor denied the right to change his nationality.

Article 16: Right to marriage and to found a family

Men and women have the right to marry when they are legally able without limits due to race, nationality, or religion. Families should be protected by the Government and the justice system.

1- Men and women of full age, without any limitation due to race, nationality or religion, have the right to marry and to found a family. They are entitled to equal rights as to marriage, during marriage and at its dissolution.

2- Marriage shall be entered into only with the free and full consent of the intending spouses.

3- The family is the natural and fundamental group unit of society and is entitled to protection by society and the State.

Article 17: Right to own property

You have the right to own things. No one has the right to illegally take them from you.

1- Everyone has the right to own property alone as well as in association with others.

2- No one shall be arbitrarily deprived of his property.

Article 18: Freedom of religion or belief

Everyone has the right to freely manifest their religion, to change it and to practice it alone or with others. Everyone has the right to freedom of thought, conscience, and religion; this right includes freedom to change his religion or belief, and freedom, either alone or in community with others and in public or private, to manifest his religion or belief in teaching, practice, worship, and observance.

Article 19: Freedom of Expression

Everyone has the right to think and say what they like and no one should forbid it. Everyone has the right to freedom of opinion and expression; this right includes freedom

to hold opinions without interference and to seek receive and impart information and ideas through any media and regardless of frontiers.

Article 20: Freedom of assembly

You have the right to organize and participate in peaceful meetings.

- 1- Everyone has the right to freedom of peaceful assembly and association.
- 2- No one may be compelled to belong to an association.

Article 21: Right to partake in public affairs

Everyone has the right to take part in their country's political affairs and equal access to public service. Governments should be voted for regularly.

- 1- Everyone has the right to take part in the government of his country, directly or through freely chosen representatives.
- 2- Everyone has the right of equal access to public service in his country.
- 3- The will of the people shall be the basis of the authority of government; this will shall be expressed in periodic and genuine elections which shall be by universal and equal suffrage and shall be held by secret vote or by equivalent free voting procedures.

Article 22: Right to social security

Society should help individuals to freely develop and make the most of all advantages offered in their country.

Everyone, as a member of society, has the right to social security and is entitled to realization, through national effort and international cooperation and in accordance with the organization and resources of each State, of the economic, social, and cultural rights indispensable for his dignity and the free development of his personality.

Article 23: Right to work

Everyone has the right to work in just and favourable conditions and be free to choose your work with a salary that allows you to live and support family. Everyone should receive equal pay for equal work.

- 1- Everyone has the right to work, to free choice of employment, to just and favourable conditions of work and to protection against unemployment.
- 2- Everyone, without any discrimination, has the right to equal pay for equal work.
- 3- Everyone who works has the right to just and favourable remuneration ensuring for himself and his family an existence worthy of human dignity, and supplemented, if necessary, by other means of social protection.
- 4- Everyone has the right to form and to join trade unions for the protection of his interests.

Article 24: Right to leisure and rest

Each work day should not be too long and everyone has the right to rest and take regular paid holidays. Everyone has the right to rest and leisure, including reasonable limitation of working hours and periodic holidays with pay.

Article 25: Right to adequate standard of living

You have the right to have what you need so that you and your family do not go hungry, homeless or fall ill.

1- Everyone has the right to a standard of living adequate for the health and well-being of himself and of his family, including foods, clothing, housing and medical care and necessary social services, and the right to security in the event of unemployment, sickness, disability, widowhood, old age or other lack of livelihood in circumstances beyond his control.

2- Motherhood and childhood are entitled to special care and assistance. All children, whether born in or out of wedlock, shall enjoy the same social protection.

Article 26: Right to education

You have the right to go to school, continue your studies as far as you wish and learn regardless of race, religion, or country of origin.

1- Everyone has the right to education. Education shall be free, at least in the elementary and fundamental stages. Elementary education shall be compulsory. Technical

and professional education shall be made generally available and higher education shall be equally accessible to all based on merit.

2- Education shall be directed to the full development of the human personality and to the strengthening of respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms. It shall promote understanding, tolerance, and friendship among all nations, racial or religious groups, and shall further the activities of the United Nations for the maintenance of peace.

3- Parents have a prior right to choose the kind of education that shall be given to their children.

Article 27: Right to take part in cultural, artistic, and scientific life

You have the right to share the benefits of your community's culture, arts, and sciences.

1- Everyone has the right freely to participate in the cultural life of the community, to enjoy the arts and to share in scientific advancement and its benefits.

2- Everyone has the right to the protection of the moral and material interests resulting from any scientific, literary, or artistic production of which he is the author.

Article 28: Right to a free and fair world

To make sure your rights are respected, there must be an order that can protect them. This order should be global. Everyone is entitled to a social and international order in which the rights and freedoms set forth in this Declaration can be fully realized.

Article 29: Duty to your community

You have duties toward the community within which your personality can fully develop. The law should guarantee human rights. It should allow everyone to respect others and to be respected.

1- Everyone has duties to the community in which alone the free and full development of his personality is possible.

2- In the exercise of his rights and freedoms, everyone shall be subject only to such limitations as are determined by law solely for the purpose of securing due recognition

and respect for the rights and freedoms of others and of meeting the just requirements of morality, public order, and the general welfare in a democratic society.

3- These rights and freedoms may in no case be exercised contrary to the purposes and principles of the United Nations.

Article 30: Rights are inalienable

No one, institution nor individual, should act in any way to destroy the rights enshrined in the UDHR. Nothing in this Declaration may be interpreted as implying for any State, group, or person any right to engage in any activity or to perform any act aimed at the destruction of any of the rights and freedoms set forth herein.

International Human Rights Law

The international human rights movement was strengthened when the United Nations General Assembly adopted the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) on 10 December 1948. Drafted as 'a common standard of achievement for all peoples and nations', the Declaration for the first time in human history spell out basic civil, political, economic, social, and cultural rights that all human beings should enjoy. It has over time been widely accepted as the fundamental norms of human rights that everyone should respect and protect. The UDHR, together with the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights and its two Optional Protocols, and the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights, form the so - called International Bill of Human Rights. A series of international human rights treaties and other instruments adopted since 1945 have conferred legal form on inherent human rights and developed the body of international human rights. Other instruments have been adopted at the regional level reflecting the human rights concerns of the region and providing for specific mechanisms of protection. Most States have also adopted constitutions and other laws which formally protect basic human rights. While international treaties and customary law form the backbone of international human rights law other instruments, such as declarations, guidelines and principles adopted at the international level contribute to its understanding, implementation, and development. Respect for human rights requires the establishment of the rule of law at the national and international levels.

International human rights law lays down obligations which States are bound to respect. By becoming parties to international treaties, States assume obligations and duties under international law to respect, to protect and to fulfil human rights. The obligation to respect means that States must refrain from interfering with or curtailing the enjoyment of human rights. The obligation to protect requires States to protect individuals and groups against human rights abuses. The obligation to fulfil means that States must take positive action to facilitate the enjoyment of basic human rights.

Through ratification of international human rights treaties, Governments undertake to put into place domestic measures and legislation compatible with their treaty obligations and duties. Where domestic legal proceedings fail to address human rights abuses, mechanisms and procedures for individual complaints or communications are available at the regional and international levels to help ensure that international human rights standards are indeed respected, implemented, and enforced at the local level.

International Bill of Human Rights

A brief history, and the two International Covenants

Following the second world war, a series of declarations and covenants began to articulate universal human rights. In 1948, for the first time, countries agreed on a comprehensive list of inalienable human rights.

In December of that year, the United Nations General Assembly adopted the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR), a milestone that would profoundly influence the development of international human rights law. In December 1966, the UN General Assembly adopted two international treaties that would further shape international human rights: the International Covenant on Economic Social and Cultural Rights (ICESCR), and the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR). These are often referred to as “the International Covenants.”

Together, the UDHR and these two Covenants are known as the International Bill of Human Rights.

The rights covered by the Covenants

The ICESCR and the ICCPR set out the civil, political, economic, social and cultural right. The Covenants identify the responsibilities placed on States to respect, protect and fulfill those rights:

Respect

- States must refrain from interfering directly or indirectly with your rights. For example, the State must not torture you or make you a slave. The State cannot force you to work in an area you have not freely chosen or stop you from speaking your language.

Protect

- States must take measures to make sure that others, such as businesses, political groups or other people do not interfere with your rights. For example, the State must stop people using hate speech against you because of where you are from or who you are. And the State has to make sure that private companies provide a fair wage for your work and do not give different salaries to men and women who do the same job.

Fulfil

- States must take steps to realize rights. For example, the State has to provide interpretation during trials if the accused cannot speak the language spoken in Court. The State must provide budgets to make sure everyone can access medicines and be free from hunger.

Examples of violations

Your civil, political, economic, cultural, and social rights can be violated through various means. Violations occur when a government fails in its obligations to respect, protect and fulfil these rights. Often a violation of one of these rights is linked to a violation of other rights. Examples include:

- Forcibly evicting people from their homes (the right to adequate housing and the right to choose his or her place of residence)
- Water treatment facilities contaminating drinking water (the right to health and the right to life)

- Failure to ensure a minimum wage sufficient for a decent living (the right to work and the right to equality before the law)
- Denying a person access to information and services related to sexual and reproductive health (the right to health and the right to life)
- Systematically segregating children with disabilities from mainstream schools (the right to education and the right to equality and non-discrimination)
- Banning the use of minority or indigenous languages (the right to participate in cultural life and the right, in community with the other members of their group, to enjoy their own culture, to profess and practice their own religion, or to use their own language)

Ratification status of the Covenants by country

The International Bill of Human Rights is a powerful statement of your rights and should persuade all Governments to respect your rights. For the two Covenants to become binding in your country, your government must ratify them. This means your government must expressly agree to abide by them.

How the Covenants are monitored

The UN Human Rights system uses different mechanisms to monitor how well the world is doing to ensure that everyone enjoys the rights set out in these Covenants.

The human rights treaty bodies are among those mechanisms. The treaty bodies are committees of independent experts that monitor implementation of the 10-core international human rights treaties, including the CCPR and the CESCR.

The following treaty bodies are responsible for monitoring the CCPR and the CESCR:

- The Human Rights Committee monitors the CCPR, and
- The Committee on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights monitors the CESCR.

What are the treaty bodies?

The human rights treaty bodies are committees of independent experts that monitor implementation of the core international human rights treaties. Each State party to a

treaty has an obligation to take steps to ensure that everyone in the State can enjoy the rights set out in the treaty. A ratification campaign is underway to encourage broader participation in the human rights treaties. There are ten human rights treaty bodies composed of independent experts of recognized competence in human rights, who are nominated and elected for fixed renewable terms of four years by State parties. The treaty bodies meet in Geneva, Switzerland. All the treaty bodies receive support from the Human Rights Treaties Division of OHCHR in Geneva.

Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination

The Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (CERD) is the body of independent experts that monitors implementation of the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination by its State parties. All States parties are obliged to submit regular reports to the Committee on how the rights are being implemented. States must report initially one year after acceding to the Convention and then every two years. The Committee examines each report and addresses its concerns and recommendations to the State party in the form of “concluding observations.”

In addition to the reporting procedure, the Convention establishes three other mechanisms through which the Committee performs its monitoring functions:

- the early warning procedure;
- the examination of inter-state complaints; and
- the examination of individual complaints.

The Committee also publishes its interpretation of the content of human rights provisions, known as general recommendations (or general comments), and organizes thematic discussions. The Committee meets in Geneva and normally holds three sessions per year consisting of three-four-three weeks per year.

The work of the Committee

The International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination, the periodic review by CERD, and the actions taken by the States parties to fulfil their obligations have had wide-ranging, positive results over the years. These include:

- Amendments to national constitutions to include provisions prohibiting racial discrimination;
- Systematic reviews of existing laws and regulations to amend those which perpetuate racial discrimination, or the passing of new laws to satisfy the requirements of the Convention;
- Amendments to the law at the suggestion of CERD;
- Making racial discrimination a punishable offence;
- Legal guarantees against discrimination in justice, security, political rights, or access to places intended for use by the general public;
- Educational programmes;
- Creation of new agencies to deal with problems of racial discrimination and to protect the interests of indigenous groups;
- Consulting CERD in advance about planned changes in the law or administrative practices.

Because States parties are answerable for their policies on racial discrimination in an international forum, this brings national law and practices into line with the Convention. Over the years, CERD and States parties have established a relationship of mutual trust; the recommendations and requests the Committee makes are generally given serious consideration.

Committee on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights

The Committee on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights (CESCR) is the body of 18 independent experts that monitors implementation of the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights by its States parties. The Committee was established under ECOSOC Resolution 1985/17 of 28 May 1985 to carry out the monitoring functions assigned to the United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) in Part IV of the Covenant. All States parties are obliged to submit regular reports to the Committee on how economic, social, and cultural rights are being implemented. States must report initially within two years of accepting the Covenant and

thereafter every five years. The Committee examines each report and addresses its concerns and recommendations to the State party in the form of “concluding observations.” In addition to the reporting procedure, the Optional Protocol to the International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights, which entered into force on 5th May 2013, gives the Committee competence to receive and consider communications from individuals claiming that their rights under the Covenant have been violated. The Committee may also, under certain circumstances, undertake inquiries on grave or systematic violations of any of the economic, social, and cultural rights set forth in the Covenant, and consider inter-state complaints. The Committee also publishes its authoritative guidance on the provisions of the Covenant, known as general comments. The Committee meets in Geneva and normally holds two sessions per year, consisting of a three-week plenary and a one-week pre-sessional working group.

The work of the Committee

The Committee monitors the implementation of the Covenant and of the Optional Protocol by State parties so that all those who are entitled to the rights in the Covenant can enjoy them in full.

It seeks to:

- develop a constructive dialogue with State parties
- determine whether the Covenant’s norms are being applied in State parties
- assess how the implementation and enforcement of the Covenant could be improved.

Drawing on the legal and practical expertise of its members, the Committee can also help States in fulfilling their obligations under the Covenant by issuing specific legislative, policy, and other recommendations so that economic, social, and cultural rights are better protected.

Human Rights Committee

The Human Rights Committee is the body of 18 independent experts that monitors implementation of the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights by its State parties. All States parties are obliged to submit regular reports to the Committee on how

civil and political rights are being implemented. States must report initially one year after acceding to the Covenant and then whenever the Committee requests. In accordance with the Predictable Review Cycle, the Committee requests the submission of the report based on an eight-year calendar. The Committee examines each report and addresses its concerns and recommendations to the State party in the form of ‘concluding observations’.

In addition,

- Article 41 of the Covenant provides for the Committee to consider inter-state complaints.
- The Optional Protocol to the Covenant gives the Committee competence to examine individual complaints regarding alleged violations of the Covenant by States parties to the Protocol.
- The Second Optional Protocol to the Covenant relates to the abolition of the death penalty by States who have accepted the Protocol.

The Committee also publishes its interpretation of the content of human rights provisions, known as general comments, on thematic issues or its methods of work. The Committee meets in Geneva and normally holds three sessions per year.

The work of the Committee

No country’s record of protecting and promoting civil and political rights is perfect and free from criticism. As a result, the Committee’s task is to encourage each State party:

1. To maintain in place those laws, policies and practices that enhance the enjoyment of these rights;
2. To withdraw or suitably amend those measures that are destructive or corrosive of Covenant rights;
3. To take appropriate positive action when a state party has failed to act to promote and protect these rights; and

4. To consider appropriately the effects in terms of the Covenant of new laws, policies, and practices that a state party proposes to introduce to ensure that it does not regress in giving practical effect to Covenant rights.

One of the great strengths of the Committee is the moral authority it derives from the fact that its membership represents all parts of the world. Instead of representing a single geographical or national perspective, the Committee speaks with a global voice. The Committee's work has a real effect in promoting the enjoyment of civil and political rights in many countries, even though the cause-and-effect relationship is at times difficult to identify. There are numerous instances of an individual complaint leading to positive results for the individual concerned, be it in the form of a payment of compensation, a commutation of a death sentence, a retrial, an investigation into events, or several other remedies, in the State party concerned.

Over the years, the Committee's work has resulted in many changes of law, policy, and practice, both at the general national level and in the context of individual cases. In a direct sense, therefore, the Committee's discharge of the monitoring functions entrusted to it under the Covenant has improved the lives of individuals in countries in all parts of the world. It is in this spirit that the Committee will continue to make its work relevant and applicable to all States parties, and to strive for the enjoyment of all civil and political rights guaranteed by the Covenant, in full and without discrimination, by all people.

Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW)

The Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW) is the body of independent experts that monitors implementation of the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women. Adopted by the United Nations in 1979, CEDAW is the most important human rights treaty for women. The CEDAW Committee consists of 23 independent experts on women's rights from around the world. The CEDAW treaty is a tool that helps women around the world to bring about change in their daily life. In countries that have ratified the treaty, CEDAW has proved invaluable in opposing the effects of discrimination, which include violence, poverty, and lack of legal protections, along with the denial of inheritance, property rights, and access to credit.

States that ratify the Convention are legally obliged to:

1. Eliminate all forms of discrimination against women in all areas of life;
2. Ensure women's full development and advancement in order that they can exercise and enjoy their human rights and fundamental freedoms in the same way as men; and
3. Allow the CEDAW Committee to scrutinize their efforts to implement the treaty by reporting to the body at regular intervals.

Countries that have become party to the treaty (States parties) must submit regular reports to the Committee on how the rights of the Convention are being implemented. During its public sessions, the Committee reviews each State party report and addresses its concerns and recommendations to the State party in the form of concluding observations.

In accordance with the Optional Protocol to the Convention, the Committee is mandated to:

1. receive communications from individuals or groups of individuals submitting claims of violations of rights protected under the Convention to the Committee and
2. initiate inquiries into situations of grave or systematic violations of women's rights. These procedures are optional and are only available where the State concerned has accepted them.

The Committee also holds days of general discussion and formulates general recommendations; these are suggestions and clarifications directed to States that concern articles or themes in the Conventions. The Committee meets in Geneva and normally holds three sessions per year, consisting of a three-week plenary and a one-week pre-session working group.

The work of the Committee

The CEDAW treaty is a tool that helps women around the world to bring about change in their daily life. In countries that have ratified the treaty, CEDAW has proved invaluable in opposing the effects of discrimination, which include violence, poverty, and lack of

legal protections, along with the denial of inheritance, property rights, and access to credit.

The treaty has contributed to the development of:

- citizenship rights in Botswana and Japan;
- inheritance rights in Tanzania;
- property rights and political participation in Costa Rica.

The CEDAW Committee has also fostered adoption of:

- a law on gender equality in Mongolia;
- a law in Rwanda prohibiting sex-based discrimination in access to land;
- domestic violence laws in Turkey, Nepal, South Africa, and the Republic of Korea;
- legislation criminalizing all forms of violence against women in Burkina Faso and femicide in Panama;
- a national inquiry into missing and murdered indigenous women in Canada; and
- anti-trafficking laws in Ukraine and Moldova.

In addition, in response to the CEDAW Committee's concluding observations, China took measures to curb cases of non-medical foetus sex identification and sex-selective abortion and to change stereotypes leading to son preference and Sri Lanka introduced gender-responsive budgeting for rural economic development projects. The Committee continues to work to protect the rights of women around the world

Committee against Torture

The Committee against Torture (CAT) is the body of 10 independent experts that monitors implementation of the Convention against Torture and Other Cruel, Inhuman or Degrading Treatment or Punishment by its States parties. The Committee against Torture works to hold States accountable for human rights violations, systematically investigating reports of torture to stop and prevent this crime.

All States parties are obliged to submit regular reports to the Committee on how the rights are being implemented. States must report initially one year after acceding to the Convention and then every four years. The Committee examines each report and addresses its concerns and recommendations to the State party in the form of "concluding observations". In addition to the reporting procedure, the Convention establishes three other mechanisms through which the Committee performs its monitoring functions. The Committee may also, under certain circumstances,

- consider individual complaints or communications from individuals claiming that their rights under the Convention have been violated,
- undertake inquiries, and
- consider inter-state complaints.

The Optional Protocol to the Convention, which entered into force in June 2006, created the Subcommittee on Prevention of Torture (SPT). The SPT has a mandate to visit places where persons are deprived of their liberty in the States parties. As of 2015, the Committee holds three four-week sessions per year in April-May, July-August, and November-December. The Committee also publishes its interpretation of the content of the provisions of the Convention, known as general comments on thematic issues.

The work of the Committee

The Convention has inspired new national laws, helped put in place important protection mechanisms and raised awareness about the needs and rights of victims. However, torture continues to plague all regions of the world, with devastating impacts on individuals and communities. Universal ratification and full implementation of the Convention are key to the future of the Committee. People need to be able to trust their institutions of justice; governments need to protect human rights instead of oppressing people. Torture has no place in the peaceful, equitable and sustainable future we are striving to build. Together, we spare no effort to banish torture, protect people, and bring torturers to justice.

Committee on the Rights of the Child

The Committee on the Rights of the Child (CRC) is the body of 18 independent experts that monitors implementation of the Convention on the Rights of the Child by its States

parties. It also monitors implementation of the Optional Protocols to the Convention, on involvement of children in armed conflict and on the sale of children, child prostitution and child pornography. Over the past 30 years, children's lives have been transformed by the most widely ratified human rights treaty in history. The Convention on the Rights of the Child has inspired governments to change laws and policies, so more children get the healthcare and nutrition they need. There are better safeguards in place to protect children from violence and exploitation. More children have their voices heard and participate in society. But there is still more work to be done.

On 19 December 2011, the UN General Assembly approved a third Optional Protocol on a communications procedure (OPIC), which allows individual children to submit complaints regarding specific violations of their rights under the Convention and its first two optional protocols. This Protocol entered into force in April 2014. All States parties are obliged to submit regular reports to the Committee on the implementation of the Convention. States must submit an initial report two years after acceding to the Convention and then periodic reports every five years. The Committee examines each report and addresses its concerns and recommendations to the State party in the form of "concluding observations." The Committee also reviews the initial reports which must be submitted by States who have acceded to the first two Optional Protocols to the Convention, on involvement of children in armed conflict and on sale of children, child prostitution and child pornography. The Committee is also able to consider individual complaints alleging violations of the Convention on the Rights of the Child and its first two optional protocols (OPAC and OPSC) by States parties to the OPIC, as well as to carry out inquiries into allegations of grave or systematic violations of rights under the Convention and its two optional protocols. The Committee meets in Geneva and normally holds three sessions per year consisting of a three-week plenary and a one-week pre-session working group.

The work of the Committee

In addition to its monitoring work, the Committee also publishes its interpretation of the content of human rights provisions, known as general comments on thematic issues, and organizes days of general discussion.

Committee on the Protection of the Rights of All Migrant Workers and Members of Their Families

The Committee on the Protection of the Rights of All Migrant Workers and Members of their Families (CMW) is the body of independent experts that works to protect the rights of the millions of migrant workers around the world.

Migrant workers and their families often experience marginalization, xenophobia, and poor living and working conditions. In serious cases, they suffer exploitation, expulsion, and risk to life. The Committee monitors how States are implementing the Convention and protecting the human rights of migrants.

Its responsibilities include:

- Examining reports from States parties, and making recommendations on the topic of migrant workers and members of their families in that State (articles 73 and 74 of the Convention);
- Organizing days of general discussion;
- Interpretations of the content of the substantive provisions in the Convention (general comments) and publishing statements and information or guidance notes on themes related to its mandate.

The Committee will also, under certain circumstances, be able to consider inter-State or individual complaints or communications from States parties or from individuals who claim that their rights under the Convention have been violated, once 10 States parties have accepted these procedures in accordance with articles 76 and 77 of the Convention. The Committee meets in Geneva and normally holds two sessions per year.

The work of the Committee

More than 280 million people, including migrant workers, refugees, asylum-seekers, permanent immigrants and others, live or work in a country other than that of their birth or citizenship. Many of them are migrant workers. The term "migrant worker" is defined by the Convention on Migrant Workers in article 2, paragraph 1, as: "a person who is to be engaged or has been engaged in a remunerated activity in a State of which he or she is not a national".

The Convention breaks new ground in defining those rights which apply to certain categories of migrant workers and their families, including frontier workers; seasonal workers; seafarers; workers on offshore installations; itinerant workers; project-tied workers; specified-employment workers; and self-employed workers. While the Convention recognizes the rights of migrant workers in an irregular situation and members of their families, who are frequently exploited and face serious human rights violations, the Committee is mandated to monitor how States protect and implement these rights. Through its work, it aims to improve the lives of migrant workers and their families.

Subcommittee on prevention of torture

The Subcommittee on Prevention of Torture and other Cruel, Inhuman or Degrading Treatment or Punishment (SPT) is a new kind of treaty body in the United Nations human rights system. It has a preventive mandate focused on a proactive approach to preventing torture and ill treatment. States that ratify the Optional Protocol to the Convention Against Torture (OPCAT) give the SPT the right to visit their places of detention and examine the treatment of people held there. The Protocol also obliges States to set up independent National Preventive Mechanisms (NPMs) to examine the treatment of people in detention, make recommendations to government authorities to strengthen protection against torture and comment on existing or proposed legislation. The SPT assists and advises NPMs in their work.

The SPT was established following the provisions of a treaty, the Optional Protocol to the Convention against Torture (OPCAT). The OPCAT was adopted on December 2002 by the General Assembly of the United Nations and entered into force in June 2006. The SPT is composed of 25 independent and impartial experts from different backgrounds and various regions of the world. Members are elected by States parties to the OPCAT for a four-year mandate and can be re-elected once.

The SPT has two primary operational functions:

1. It may undertake visits to States parties, during which it may visit any place where persons may be deprived of their liberty.

2. It has an advisory function which involves providing assistance and advice to States parties on the establishment of National Preventive Mechanisms (“NPM”), which OPCAT requires that they establish, and also providing advice and assistance to both the NPM and the State Party regarding the working of the NPM.

The SPT cooperates, for the prevention of torture in general, with relevant United Nations organs and mechanisms as well as with international, regional, and national institutions or organizations. The SPT produces a public annual report on its activities which it presents to the Committee against Torture and the UN General Assembly in New York. In addition to its field work, the SPT also convenes three times a year for one week-long sessions at the United Nations Office at Geneva.

The work of the Committee

The SPT examines the way in which detainees are treated whilst in detention, as well as looking at the conditions of detention.

SPT members talk in private with people in custody, without the presence of prison or other staff or of Governmental representatives.

During its country visits, SPT members also talk with Government officials, custodial staff, lawyers, and doctors, and can recommend immediate changes intended to improve the situation of detainees. Their work is governed by strict confidentiality and they do not reveal who they have spoken to, or what they have been told. People who provide information to the SPT must not be subject to sanctions or reprisals for having provided information to the SPT. The SPT is guided by the principles of confidentiality, impartiality, non-selectivity, universality and objectivity. The SPT conducts its work in a spirit of co-operation. It aims to engage with States parties through a process of constructive dialogue and collaboration rather than condemnation.

Committee on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (CRPD)

The Committee is the body of 18 independent experts which monitors the implementation of the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities by the States parties. All States parties submit regular reports to the Committee on how the rights enshrined in the Convention are being implemented. States must report initially within two years of

ratifying the Convention and, thereafter, every four years (Article 35 of the Convention). The Committee examines each report and makes recommendations to strengthen the implementation of the Convention in that State. It forwards these recommendations, in the form of concluding observations, to the State party concerned.

The Optional Protocol ([A/RES/61/106](#)) which entered into force at the same time as the Convention, also allows the Committee to:

1. Receive and examine individual complaints; and
2. Undertake inquiries in the case of reliable evidence of grave and systematic violations of the Convention.

The Committee also publishes its interpretation of the content of human rights provisions, known as general comments, on thematic issues. The Committee normally meets in Geneva and holds two sessions per year.

The work of the Committee

The Committee's monitoring mandate is carried out on the basis of a new understanding of disability. According to the human rights model of disability, disability is a social construct. It is the barriers within society, rather than personal impairments, that exclude persons with disabilities. Worldwide, there are an estimated 15% - or more than one billion people, who are persons with disabilities. The Committee has noted that the failure to understand and implement the human rights model of disability is a major cause of discrimination and exclusion of persons with disabilities in society.

Through its engagement and cooperation with States parties, the Committee advocates for the human rights of persons with disabilities, and provides States parties with recommendations to support the implementation of provisions enshrined in the Convention. In its work, particularly its Concluding observations, general comments, Views on individual communications and inquiry findings, the Committee has clarified how States parties must understand and implement the human rights model of disability. This model does not allow the exclusion of persons with disabilities from the community or from any area of life for any reason.

The COVID-19 pandemic has revealed that States parties have not comprehensively implemented the Convention. Entrenched discrimination and inequality against persons with disabilities, together with persisting attitudinal, environmental, and institutional barriers result in situations of vulnerability and risks for persons with disabilities. The Committee has consistently highlighted that States parties must ensure that persons with disabilities and their organizations are included in all initiatives and decision-making processes that relate to persons with disabilities.

Committee on Enforced Disappearances (CED)

The Committee on Enforced Disappearances (CED) is the body of independent experts which monitors the implementation of the Convention by the States parties. Specifically, its responsibilities include:

- Examining reports from States parties, and making recommendations on the topic of enforced disappearances in that State (article 29 of the Convention).
- Registering requests for urgent action (article 30 of the Convention).
- Receiving individual complaints from victims of a violation of the Convention by a State party (article 31 of the Convention).
- Receiving communications in which a State party claims that another State party is not fulfilling its obligations under the Convention; so-called inter-state communications (article 32 of the Convention).

The Committee meets in Geneva and holds two sessions per year. For more information about the work of the Committee, read the Committee on Enforced Disappearances Fact sheet.

The mandate of the Committee

Enforced disappearance is a crime which, if practiced in a ‘widespread’ or ‘systematic’ manner, may amount to a crime against humanity. It affects all regions of the world and amounts to a violation of a range of human rights: of the disappeared persons, of their relatives, and of the wider community.

The International Convention for the Protection of All Persons from Enforced Disappearance is designed to protect all persons from enforced disappearances, to prevent their occurrence, to provide support to victims and guide States as to the measures to take to promote the rights of the Convention, and enhance cooperation and assistance between States. It stipulates the creation of a Committee on Enforced Disappearances charged with the following tasks:

- To examine reports submitted by States parties on the measures taken to give effect to their obligations under the Convention;
- To send urgent actions to States, requesting that they take all the necessary measures, including interim measures, to locate and protect a disappeared person. This is the first time that a mandate of such nature is given to a treaty-monitoring body;
- To receive and consider communications from individuals claiming to be victims of a violation by a State party of provisions of the Convention;
- To receive and consider communications in which a State party claims that another State party is not fulfilling its obligations under the Convention;
- To undertake visits to any State party, after consultation with the State concerned, if it receives information indicating that this State is seriously violating the provisions of the Convention.

If the Committee receives well-founded information that enforced disappearance is being practised on a widespread or systematic basis in a State party, it may also bring the matter to the attention of the General Assembly, through the Secretary-General, after seeking information from the State concerned.

How the CED and the WGEID cooperate and coordinate

The Committee on Enforced Disappearances and the Working Group on Enforced or Involuntary Disappearances (WGEID) coexist and cooperate to assist States in their fight against enforced disappearances. This collaboration considers that:

- The Committee can intervene only in the States that have ratified the Convention, while the Working Group is able to consider the situation in all countries.

- The Committee may only deal with cases of enforced disappearance which occurred after the entry into force of the Convention on 23 December 2010, while the Working Group may examine all situations before that.

In summary, if a case or situation of concern occurs in a State party to the Convention and relates to a disappearance that occurred after 23 December 2010, the Committee is able to get involved. Otherwise, please refer to the Working Group on Enforced and Involuntary Disappearances.

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Basic Human Needs (BHN)

The concept of **basic human needs** has been central to disciplines such as psychology, sociology, anthropology, development studies, and peace and conflict resolution. Human needs are generally defined as **essential conditions or requirements that must be satisfied for individuals to survive, develop, and live with dignity**. Unlike desires or wants, which are culturally specific and negotiable, needs are **universal, non-negotiable, and deeply tied to human well-being**. The recognition of basic human needs serves not only as a foundation for understanding human motivation but also as a critical tool in addressing social inequalities, development challenges, and the root causes of conflict. However, the notion of needs is not without criticism, particularly regarding its cultural applicability, hierarchy, and measurement.

John Burton's Basic Human Needs Theory (1990s)

John Burton, a pioneering scholar in conflict resolution, developed the Basic Human Needs (BHN) Theory as part of his broader contributions to human needs theory in the 1970s and 1980s. According to Burton (1990), conflicts—particularly protracted or deep-rooted ones—cannot be adequately explained or resolved through traditional power-based negotiation or

coercive strategies. Instead, they arise from the denial or frustration of fundamental human needs that are universal, non-negotiable, and essential for human dignity and well-being.

Burton identified needs such as security, recognition, identity, belonging, and personal development as core to human existence. Unlike material interests, which can be bargained or compromised, these needs cannot simply be traded off in negotiations. If ignored, the suppression of these needs' fuels persistent resentment and recurring cycles of conflict. For instance, identity-based conflicts, such as ethnic or religious disputes, often persist because they involve recognition and respect, not just material resources.

The BHN theory is closely aligned with the idea that peacebuilding requires addressing structural and cultural violence (Galtung, 1996). Burton argued that sustainable conflict resolution must move beyond the surface-level management of disputes and instead transform underlying relationships by ensuring that basic needs are met. This approach laid the foundation for problem-solving workshops, a method Burton championed, where conflicting parties engage in dialogue to explore unmet needs and generate creative solutions.

In practice, the theory emphasizes the importance of inclusive governance, social justice, and mechanisms that allow marginalized groups to express and reveal their needs. For example, in post-conflict societies, peacebuilding processes that prioritize truth, reconciliation, and social inclusion align with Burton's assertion that satisfying basic needs is essential for lasting peace. In conflict resolution, John Burton emphasized that **identity, recognition, security, and autonomy** are **non-negotiable needs**. Conflicts often arise when such needs are denied by political, social, or economic structures.

- Unlike interests (which can be compromised), **needs cannot be traded away**.
- Sustainable peace requires addressing unmet human needs rather than suppressing conflict symptoms.

Characteristics of Basic Human Needs

1. **Universality** – Shared by all human beings regardless of culture or geography.
2. **Non-negotiability** – Needs differ from interests; they cannot be permanently suppressed or exchanged.

3. **Interdependence** – Neglect of one need often undermines others (e.g., lack of security undermines belonging).
4. **Contextual satisfaction** – While needs are universal, their satisfaction is culturally shaped (e.g., food as subsistence may differ across regions).
5. **Dynamic nature** – Needs may manifest differently across time and social transformation (e.g., digital access as part of security or participation in the 21st century).

Critical Evaluation

1. **Holistic perspective:** Goes beyond survival to include psychological and social well-being.
2. **Policy application:** Useful in welfare planning, education, health, and conflict transformation.
3. **Conflict resolution utility:** Explains intractable conflicts (ethnic, cultural, or national) as struggles for unmet needs, not just interests.
4. **Universal framework:** Provides a shared vocabulary for understanding human development across disciplines.

Limitations

1. **Hierarchical rigidity (Maslow):** Human behaviour often defies linear progression; people may prioritize identity or dignity over survival (e.g., hunger strikes, self-sacrifice).
2. **Cultural bias:** Western models emphasize individual autonomy, whereas non-Western traditions stress community, spirituality, or collective harmony.
3. **Measurement challenge:** Needs are abstract and difficult to operationalize in empirical research.
4. **Over-generalization:** Assumes universality but overlooks individual variation and historical context.
5. **Neglect of power and inequality:** Some theories do not adequately account for structural violence, systemic oppression, or unequal access to resources.
6. **Risk of reductionism:** Explaining all human motivation through “needs” may neglect values, ideologies, or higher moral/spiritual aspirations.

Examples in Practice

- Development Policy:

The **UNDP's Human Development Index (HDI)** integrates health, education, and income as indicators of basic needs fulfilment.

- Conflict Situations:

Ethnic or religious conflicts often stem from **unmet needs for recognition and identity** (e.g., Northern Ireland, Sri Lanka, or caste-based struggles in India).

- Cross-Cultural Contexts:

- In **India**, family and community serve as primary satisfiers for belonging, protection, and identity.

- In the **West**, emphasis often lies on individual autonomy and freedom as central satisfiers.

- Contemporary Relevance:

Access to the internet, digital literacy, and climate security are increasingly debated as **emerging basic needs** in a globalized world.

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Understanding Human and Environmental Conflicts

People and the Environment

Daily (1999, cited in Le Maitre et al., 2007:369) outlines a wide spectrum of ecosystem services that nature provides, including:

- Stabilising and regulatory functions: purification and maintenance of atmospheric gases, regulation of the hydrological cycle, partial climate stabilisation, moderation of extreme weather events, and control of most potential pest species.
- Regeneration functions: renewal of soil fertility, purification of water, detoxification and decomposition of wastes, pollination, and seed/spore dispersal that enables vegetation renewal.
- Production of goods: provision of food, raw materials, industrial products, genetic resources, and pharmaceuticals.
- Life-enriching functions: aesthetic beauty, tranquillity, opportunities for scientific discovery, and safeguarding future options.

These ecosystem services demonstrate the critical role natural processes play in maintaining Earth's systems, human survival, livelihoods, and lifestyles. Nature, as a resource, directly or indirectly supplies food, space for habitation, health and medicinal resources, energy, and livelihood materials (Bob et al., 2008:17). There is widespread acknowledgment that Earth's resources are finite and operate within a single, complex, and interconnected system. As Steffen et al. (2004:2) note:

“The environment at the scale of the Earth as a whole – the seasonal cycles, variations in weather and climate, the ebb and flow of rivers and glaciers, and the vast diversity of life – has always been the context in which human activity occurs, shaped primarily by powerful natural forces and occasional extraterrestrial events. Earth's environment has served as both a generous source of resources and a stable life-support system, enabling human civilisations to thrive.”

This illustrates the deep and inseparable relationship between humans and societal development. Over time, human capacity to control and modify the environment has

increased substantially, making people both the custodians and primary consumers of natural resources. However, the unprecedented scale of global population and human activity has placed immense strain on natural systems, resulting in widespread environmental transformation (Steffen et al., 2004:2). For instance, global economic activity grew nearly tenfold between 1950 and 2000, while the world's population doubled from under 3 billion to 6 billion. With globalisation, economies and information systems have become more interlinked than ever before. Ahmed (2010) highlights how population growth exacerbates environmental stress, particularly in fragile coastal areas. Similarly, Moodley et al. (2010) examine the connections between Rwanda's genocide, high population density, land scarcity, and the manipulation of natural resources such as land to incite violence. These cases underscore the challenge of meeting the United Nations' Millennium Development Goal of halving extreme poverty without unsustainable exploitation of natural systems (Barrett et al., 2005:193).

At the same time, environmental conditions—whether naturally occurring or human-induced—such as rainfall variability, earthquakes, tsunamis, terrain, water availability, and land quality, are key sources of vulnerability and insecurity. Such shocks often overwhelm household and community coping capacities, particularly among poorer populations that lack infrastructure and resources. As Reuveny (2007:661) stresses: *“The key issue is not how strong a disaster is per se, but rather how strong it is relative to the ability of people to withstand it.”*

Access to natural resources is equally central to livelihood security, especially for poorer households that rely directly on these resources. However, livelihood activities may themselves lead to resource degradation through overuse, resulting in deforestation, soil erosion, desertification, declining water tables, and other forms of ecological damage. These processes create a vicious cycle: environmental degradation intensifies poverty, which in turn fuels greater resource exploitation, contributing to what is commonly termed the “poverty trap.” Competition over dwindling resources often escalates into household or community-level conflicts. Several contributions highlight the role of vulnerability in environmental conflicts. Perry et al. (2010) emphasise that women, due to unequal power relations and restricted access to resources, often bear a disproportionate burden of environmental change. Jaggernath (2010) explores how economic growth, industrialisation, environmental racism,

and air pollution generate conflict, particularly when marginalised communities suffer the greatest environmental and health costs of development.

Given these dynamics, it becomes imperative to understand how ecosystems function and respond to both natural and anthropogenic changes. As Ashton et al. (2005:449) argue, *“ecological processes are important from a human-needs perspective, for the goods and services they provide.”* Many environmental conflicts arise directly from struggles to secure control over these goods and services. In this regard, Okech (2010) highlights conservation efforts, where biodiversity protection often entails restricting human access to certain ecosystem goods and services. Yet, as Bob (2010) notes, conservation and land restitution processes in Sub-Saharan Africa reveal a dilemma: forced relocations to establish conservation areas have led to contested land claims. Prolonged delays in addressing these claims have sometimes resulted in illegal land occupation, causing further environmental degradation and intensifying conflict.

Environmental Conflicts

Scholars such as Castro and Nielson (2003) and Yasmi et al. (2006) argue that conflicts arise when stakeholders possess irreconcilable differences in interests, values, perceptions, power, or goals. When such disputes are not resolved or adequately managed, they tend to escalate in intensity. As White et al. (2009:244) note, *“What distinguishes conflicts from mere disagreement is thus a behavioural expression of formerly latent attitudes where one party is perceived to take action at the expense of another party’s interests.”* Manifestations of such conflicts may include threats, physical violence, appropriation of resources, insurgencies, skirmishes, and even interstate or intrastate wars (Reuveny, 2007:656). Competition over limited natural resources, contrasting worldviews, and institutional weaknesses all contribute to the emergence and intensification of environmental conflicts (Hellström, 2001). Central to this discussion is the notion of scarcity—whether real or perceived—which underpins many of these conflicts. In fact, most environmental disputes can broadly be understood as scarcity-related conflicts.

The literature identifies several categories of environmental conflicts, including:

1. **Biodiversity conflicts** – These occur when people disagree over the management of wildlife or other aspects of biodiversity (White et al., 2009:242). They encompass disputes

surrounding protected areas, green technologies, fair trade, and intellectual property rights linked to biodiversity and indigenous knowledge. International dimensions of such conflicts make them particularly complex, carrying serious policy and regulatory implications. Issues such as land clearance for development, agricultural expansion, and the effects of genetically modified crops on biodiversity further complicate matters. Importantly, conservation policies that fail to balance ecological and human needs often generate conflict. For example, Okech (2010) shows how, in Kenya, wildlife protection has sometimes led to communities suffering crop and livestock losses, prompting retaliatory killings of animals. Closely related are natural resource management (NRM) conflicts, which, as Yasmi et al. (2006:538) observe, are increasing in frequency and complexity due to the involvement of multiple actors and competing management strategies. Crucially, such conflicts can turn violent and transcend national boundaries.

2. Coastal zone conflicts – Coastal regions often combine features of multiple conflict types due to their ecological and socio-economic importance. Ahmed (2010) highlights that high development pressures, dense populations, environmental degradation, and fragmented governance make these zones particularly vulnerable. Conflicts in coastal areas typically revolve around two themes: ecosystem changes and disputes arising from coastal development projects.

3. Conflicts disproportionately affecting women – Women are especially vulnerable to environmental conflicts due to physical, economic, social, and political inequalities. Several studies in this issue emphasise how women bear a disproportionate burden of environmental stress. Perry et al. (2010) note that women often face heightened food and economic insecurity and are exposed to unsafe or exploitative practices. In Kenya, Omolo (2010) found that cattle raids, often linked to drought conditions, place women in pastoral communities at risk. Similarly, Bob (2010) documents how apartheid-era land scarcity left women vulnerable to abandonment, violence, and dispossession of land, particularly widows.

4. Conflicts over air quality and pollutants – Disputes over air pollution and exposure to hazardous substances represent another prominent type of environmental conflict, often tied to issues of social justice and the right to a healthy environment. Jaggernath (2010) and Mix and Shriver (2007) highlight how such conflicts frequently involve divergent perceptions of environmental risks, complicating conflict management. Environmental racism and the

intersection of poverty with vulnerability emerge as key themes in these disputes. While many such conflicts manifest in demonstrations, litigation, or community mobilisation, they may also escalate into violent confrontations. The case of the South Durban Basin (SDB) in South Africa illustrates how air quality conflicts can attract widespread media attention and public debate.

Other Key Types of Environmental Conflicts

Land Conflicts

Across the globe, and particularly in Africa, land remains a critical livelihood resource. As Kok et al. (2009:42) observe:

The importance of land in conflicts relates to people's ability to make a living or generate profit. Land scarcity or unclear property rights can heighten grievances and escalate into violent conflict, especially where alternative livelihoods are absent and communities are armed. Moreover, where land contains valuable mineral resources, disputes may arise between local communities and external actors seeking resource extraction. Population growth and migration, global market dynamics, insecure property rights and legislation, climate change, and environmental degradation are all key variables shaping land-related conflicts. Additionally, desertification, unsustainable land use, or drought often intensify competition between communities reliant on competing livelihoods.

Bob (2010) highlights land conflicts in Sub-Saharan Africa, pointing to the interplay of power, poverty, and inequality in shaping land access and tenure. Land has also been manipulated as a political tool. For instance, Moodley et al. (2010) emphasise its role in the Rwandan genocide: although not the primary cause, land scarcity was instrumental in mobilising citizens whose vulnerable livelihoods, threatened by shrinking landholdings, were incited to seize neighbours' land and assets through violence. This process created destructive feedback loops, where genocide-induced deforestation and environmental degradation generated further tensions.

Water Conflicts

Water scarcity has been described as a looming global challenge. Klare (2001:57, cited in Gleditsch et al., 2006:362) warns that by 2050, rising demand will trigger "*intense*

competition for this essential substance in all but a few well-watered areas of the planet.” Shared river basins heighten risks of military disputes or “water wars” (Gleditsch et al., 2006:361), especially since many countries depend on water sources beyond their borders. Competition over water and aquatic resources such as fish increasingly threatens both national security and local livelihoods, particularly in contested or poorly demarcated boundary regions. Onuoha (2008:35) illustrates this in the case of Lake Chad, where diminishing water resources have sparked disputes in Cameroon, Chad, Niger, and Nigeria, involving fishermen, pastoralists, farmers, and even state security forces. These disputes have frequently escalated into intra-ethnic, intra-state, and inter-state conflicts. Water scarcity is also directly linked to food security, since water is essential for agriculture. In Tanzania’s Pangani River Basin, for example, migration in search of water has led to tensions between farmers and pastoralists, rapid population growth, and clashes over competing water uses, including irrigation and hydropower generation (Mbonile, 2005:41).

Climate Change and Environmental Conflicts

Climate change is increasingly recognised as a driver of environmental conflict, intensifying existing vulnerabilities and creating new forms of insecurity (IPCC, 2007). Thomas and Twyman (2005:122) emphasise the need to examine linkages across global processes (such as emissions and international conventions), national policies, and local adaptation outcomes. Steffen et al. (2004:16) identify both proximate drivers (e.g., deforestation, land conversion, fossil fuel use, poor water management) and underlying drivers (growing demand for food, water, energy, transport, and luxury goods) that contribute to climate change.

The socio-political implications of climate variability are not new. For example, Davis (2001, cited in Barnett & Adger, 2007:641) demonstrates how El Niño-triggered droughts in the 19th century facilitated political and economic colonisation, stripping local populations of their resource entitlements. Barnett and Adger (2007:642) argue that violent conflict itself exacerbates human vulnerability to climate change, while Thomas and Twyman (2005:115) stress that climate change raises critical questions of equity and justice, as its effects fall disproportionately on poorer and more resource-dependent populations. Barnett and Adger (2007:639) also note that climate change is increasingly viewed as a security threat, reducing resource availability and undermining human security, particularly in developing contexts.

Nordås and Gleditsch (2007:627) acknowledge emerging evidence of climate–conflict linkages but highlight the need for more empirical substantiation.

Case studies provide further insights. Omolo (2010) documents how drought in Kenya has intensified competition for grazing land and water, fuelling violence and militarised cattle raids, especially as economic decline worsens vulnerabilities. Reuveny (2007:656) shows how climate-induced migration—prompted by extreme weather events—can generate or intensify conflict, particularly in developing countries with limited adaptive capacity. The Christian Aid Charity (cited in Nordås & Gleditsch, 2007:629) warns that climate change could displace over one billion people globally and cause up to 184 million deaths in Africa alone by the end of the 21st century.

Environmental migration, driven by land degradation, drought, deforestation, floods, storms, and food insecurity (Reuveny, 2007:662), further complicates conflict dynamics. Development itself can also cause displacement. For instance, Jaggernath (2010) reports that 78% of residents in South Durban Basin would relocate if compensated, while Omolo (2010) highlights how women in pastoral communities often migrate to cities during environmental stress, with some turning to precarious livelihoods such as prostitution to survive.

Resolving Environmental Conflicts

Conflicts related to the environment are deeply embedded within political, economic, social, and ecological contexts. Yet, only a limited number of studies and intervention strategies adopt an integrated and interdisciplinary approach to addressing them. More often, such conflicts are examined in a fragmented manner, with emphasis placed on a single dimension while others are overlooked. It is essential to highlight that the very notion of “conflict” underscores its social and political dimensions, particularly power relations and social dynamics. Importantly, not all environmental conflicts lead to negative outcomes. On the contrary, they can serve as critical entry points for addressing broader social, economic, and ecological challenges. From an ecological standpoint, conflicts can draw attention to environmental degradation and even stimulate conservation initiatives. As White et al. (2009:243) observe, conflict management is vital not only to mitigate adverse effects but also to enhance potential positive outcomes.

Effective planning is a fundamental requirement for successful management and implementation, though it often remains aspirational rather than operational (Paterson, 2007:4). Ahmed (2008:45) points out that despite the growing prominence of environmental agendas and widespread governmental advocacy for management strategies, prevailing approaches remain largely regional, sectoral, and unsustainable. This is the case even with the proliferation of international agreements, treaties, and policies. Moreover, inappropriate land-use planning and weak policy implementation exacerbate the situation, frequently leading to ad hoc or misguided interventions. Such shortcomings have serious repercussions, not only undermining the biophysical environment and long-term ecological sustainability but also disproportionately affecting marginalized and vulnerable populations.

Legal and procedural instruments such as Environmental Impact Assessments (EIAs), Social Impact Assessments (SIAs), and Strategic Environmental Assessments (SEAs) remain crucial in governing environmental issues, especially in relation to ongoing and planned development activities. Nevertheless, the effective application of these tools necessitates careful attention to a wide array of interconnected factors. These considerations form the basis for broader recommendations on managing environmental conflicts.

Conclusion

Environmental conflicts manifest in diverse forms and generate varied impacts across different contexts. The major sources of such conflicts include climate change, conservation efforts, water scarcity and quality, air pollution, and broader resource management concerns. A particularly alarming trend is the increasing levels of migration driven by environmental and related conflicts, which often give rise to new tensions or exacerbate existing ones in host regions.

Vulnerability remains central to understanding environmental conflicts. Marginalized groups—especially the poor and women—are disproportionately affected by environmental degradation and its associated conflicts. Their dependence on natural resources for subsistence and energy not only heightens their exposure to environmental risks but also contributes to further degradation. Environmental depletion and the competition over scarce resources, in turn, fuel conflicts ranging from local disputes to international crises. Yet, an underexplored dimension is how violent conflicts themselves—through warfare, displacement, and the destruction of property—accelerate environmental degradation. Such

processes weaken the resource base, intensify scarcity, and perpetuate cycles of poverty, inequality, and vulnerability. The natural environment often becomes a target of exploitation and looting during conflict, as highlighted by Le Billon (2001:561), who noted that resources not only finance but sometimes even motivate conflicts, shaping power strategies through their commercialization. The looming impacts of climate change are expected to amplify these risks, making environmental conflicts increasingly widespread and urgent.

Consequently, environmental conflicts and the threats they pose are emerging as critical concerns for security and conflict studies. Their implications extend into political processes and governance, requiring states and institutions to anticipate stress points and build mechanisms for prevention and resilience. Given their scale and complexity, environmental conflicts influence ecological, social, political, and economic stability simultaneously. They thus represent a profound threat to both natural systems and human security, underscoring the necessity of advancing research, resolution, and sustainable management strategies.

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Development and Environment Debate

The debate between economic development and environmental preservation is one of the most significant challenges in the 21st century. It is not merely a question of economics versus ecology, but a fundamental inquiry into the meaning of progress, the limits of growth, and the sustainability of human civilization. On one hand, development requires resource extraction, industrialization, and infrastructure expansion to meet the needs of growing populations. On the other hand, environmental conservation calls for restraint, ecological protection, and sustainable practices that ensure long-term survival. The tension lies in balancing these imperatives in ways that protect human welfare without undermining the planet’s life-support systems.

1. The Development Imperative

Proponents of development argue that economic growth is the foundation of human advancement. Growth creates jobs, reduces poverty, and provides access to critical services such as healthcare, education, and sanitation (Todaro & Smith, 2015). In countries like China and India, rapid industrialization has lifted hundreds of millions of people out of poverty while transforming these nations into global economic powers. For such nations, development is not merely about wealth accumulation—it represents a moral obligation to improve living standards and address basic human needs (Sen, 1999).

Furthermore, advocates emphasize that development enables states to build political stability and international competitiveness. They argue that growth and industrialization are necessary to reduce inequality and empower marginalized communities. Additionally, technological progress promises to make development less ecologically damaging. For instance, clean energy sources, sustainable transportation, and advanced agricultural techniques are increasingly promoted as tools for achieving both prosperity and environmental protection (Sachs, 2015). From this standpoint, the key challenge is not whether to pursue growth, but how to make it sustainable and inclusive.

2. Environmental Concerns

Environmentalists caution that traditional development models—anchored in fossil fuels, deforestation, and mass industrialization—are fundamentally unsustainable (Meadows et al., 1972). The unchecked exploitation of resources has led to climate change, biodiversity loss, air and water pollution, and soil degradation, creating risks that extend beyond national borders. The expansion of agriculture and urban areas into forests and wetlands disrupts critical ecosystems that regulate carbon cycles and maintain water security. Rising greenhouse gas emissions, for instance, threaten not only agriculture but also human health, coastal cities, and global biodiversity (IPCC, 2021).

From this perspective, the pursuit of short-term economic gains undermines long-term planetary stability. Environmentalists argue that conservation is not a luxury but a necessity for survival. They highlight how fragile ecosystems, once destroyed, cannot easily be restored, and the cost of ecological collapse far outweighs immediate developmental benefits. Thus, the environmentalist position insists on rethinking growth models to prioritize sustainability, resource efficiency, and ecological resilience over relentless consumption (Carson, 1962).

3. The Concept of Sustainable Development

Sustainable development has emerged as a framework for reconciling these conflicting priorities. Defined by the Brundtland Commission (1987) as development that “meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs,” it integrates economic, social, and ecological dimensions. This vision is institutionalized in the United Nations’ Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), which

commit nations to poverty reduction, clean energy, climate action, and responsible consumption. Concrete strategies of sustainability include investment in renewable energy, adoption of circular economies, eco-friendly building designs, and sustainable agricultural systems such as agroforestry and organic farming. These practices not only protect ecosystems but also support food security, job creation, and long-term resilience (Rockström et al., 2009). Yet, critics point out that achieving sustainability is far more challenging in developing countries, where urgent demands for growth often override environmental priorities. Limited financial resources, dependence on extractive industries, and lack of technological capacity further hinder progress.

4. The Role of Technology and Innovation

A central counterargument to environmental pessimism is that technology can decouple growth from ecological harm. Historically, the Green Revolution of the mid-20th century—through the introduction of high-yield crops, fertilizers, and irrigation techniques—transformed food production and alleviated hunger in Asia and Latin America (Evenson & Gollin, 2003). Similarly, today’s technological advances in solar and wind power, electric vehicles, water recycling, and energy-efficient buildings provide opportunities to reduce ecological footprints while sustaining development.

Advocates such as Arthur Mol (2001) argue that technological modernization and “ecological restructuring” can enable nations to grow without repeating the destructive paths of early industrialized economies. However, critics caution against technological optimism, noting that many innovations are expensive, unevenly distributed, and often introduce new ecological or social risks. The promise of technology, therefore, must be coupled with strong governance, regulation, and equitable access to ensure that innovation contributes to sustainability rather than deepening inequalities.

5. Globalization and Environmental Justice

Another critical aspect of the debate involves environmental justice and equity. The burdens of ecological degradation are disproportionately borne by poorer communities, particularly in the Global South, who have contributed the least to environmental damage but suffer the greatest consequences (Martinez-Alier, 2002). For instance, climate-induced floods, droughts, and food insecurity disproportionately affect vulnerable populations in Africa and South Asia,

while wealthier nations often have the resources to adapt. This raises ethical questions about fairness in global development. Should developing nations restrict their growth to protect the environment when industrialized nations historically built their wealth on resource exploitation? Advocates of environmental justice call for more equitable solutions: financial aid, technology transfer, and climate funds to help poorer countries adopt sustainable paths (Shiva, 2005). International agreements such as the Paris Climate Accord emphasize the principle of “common but differentiated responsibilities,” recognizing that developed countries must take greater responsibility for addressing global environmental crises.

Conclusion

The debate between development and environmental protection cannot be reduced to a binary choice. Both are essential: development ensures poverty alleviation, human dignity, and economic resilience, while environmental conservation guarantees the survival of ecosystems that sustain human life. The real challenge lies in integrating the two through sustainable development, guided by innovation, equity, and strong global cooperation. Ultimately, the way forward depends on political will, technological adaptation, and international solidarity. Nations must pursue policies that encourage renewable energy, reduce waste, and support inclusive growth. At the same time, developed countries must support developing ones in balancing their growth aspirations with ecological responsibility. Only by achieving this delicate balance can humanity secure prosperity while safeguarding the planet for future generations.

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United Nations

The United Nations (UN), an international organization, was formally established on October 24, 1945. It was the second multipurpose global organization of the 20th century with universal scope and membership, following the League of Nations, which had been created under the Treaty of Versailles (1919) and dissolved in 1946. The UN is headquartered in New York City, with major regional offices in Geneva, Vienna, and Nairobi. Its official languages are Arabic, Chinese, English, French, Russian, and Spanish.

According to its Charter, the UN is committed:

- *to save succeeding generations from the scourge of war,*
- *to reaffirm faith in fundamental human rights,*
- *to uphold justice and respect for international law,*
- *and to promote social progress and better standards of life in greater freedom.*

Beyond maintaining international peace and security, the UN's objectives include fostering friendly relations among states based on the principle of equal rights and self-determination, encouraging global cooperation to address economic, social, cultural, and humanitarian challenges, advancing human rights, and serving as a central platform for states to coordinate collective action. While the UN inherited many functions and structures from the League of Nations, it also represented a distinctive institution, especially through its broader commitment to peacekeeping, economic development, and social progress.

The UN's role evolved alongside changes in international relations. During its first 45 years, Cold War rivalries between the United States and the Soviet Union limited its effectiveness in security matters. However, the wave of post-World War II decolonization in Africa, Asia, and the Middle East expanded its responsibilities in political, social, and economic domains. The end of the Cold War in 1991 revived expectations of the UN, but also presented new challenges in conflict resolution and humanitarian operations. Entering the 21st century, the organization faced mounting pressures from civil wars, humanitarian crises, refugee movements, the global spread of AIDS, financial instability, terrorism, and the widening gap between the world's richest and poorest populations.

Historical Background and Evolution

Despite the shortcomings of the League of Nations in preventing conflict before World War II, the Allied powers resolved during the war to create a new body capable of managing international peace and cooperation. This idea was first articulated in the Atlantic Charter (August 1941), signed by U.S. President Franklin D. Roosevelt and British Prime Minister Winston Churchill. The term *United Nations* was initially applied to the coalition of countries fighting against Germany, Italy, and Japan. On January 1, 1942, 26 states signed the *Declaration by United Nations*, pledging their commitment to the Allied war aims.

The formation of the new organization was led primarily by the United States, the United Kingdom, and the Soviet Union. However, differences soon emerged among the “Big Three”—Roosevelt, Churchill, and Soviet Premier Joseph Stalin—foreshadowing Cold War tensions. The Soviet Union insisted on separate membership and voting rights for its republics, while Britain sought assurances regarding the status of its colonies. Moreover, debates arose over the voting system of the Security Council, particularly the controversial *veto power* issue, which remains central to the UN's decision-making process.

The formation of the United Nations progressed through several major conferences. At the Dumbarton Oaks Conference (August–October 1944), the Big Three powers—later joined by China—outlined the basic structure and purposes of a new global organization, though disputes over membership and voting persisted. These issues were partly resolved at the Yalta Conference (February 1945), where Roosevelt, Churchill, and Stalin agreed on the Security Council's authority, Soviet membership, and the inclusion of a trusteeship system. The proposals from both conferences shaped the negotiations at the San Francisco Conference

(April–June 1945), attended by 50 states, which ultimately produced and unanimously adopted the UN Charter, signed on June 26, 1945, and entering into force on October 24, 1945.

The UN Charter set forth key principles, including sovereign equality, peaceful dispute resolution, non-intervention in domestic affairs, and collective assistance in maintaining peace and security. Membership admission required Security Council recommendation and a two-thirds General Assembly vote, but Cold War divisions often complicated expansion. Notable cases included the admission of 16 states in 1955, the contested entry of the People's Republic of China in 1971, and the gradual inclusion of divided states such as Germany, Vietnam, and Korea. Decolonization in the mid-20th century and the breakup of the Soviet Union further expanded membership, bringing it close to 190 by the early 21st century.

Principal Organs

The United Nations functions through six principal organs: the General Assembly, the Security Council, the Economic and Social Council, the Trusteeship Council, the International Court of Justice, and the Secretariat.

General Assembly

The General Assembly is the only body where all UN member states are represented. It serves primarily as a deliberative forum, discussing issues and making recommendations but lacking enforcement power. Its responsibilities include admitting new members, electing nonpermanent members of the Security Council, selecting judges of the International Court of Justice, supervising other UN organs, and appointing the secretary-general. Most decisions are made by a simple majority, but crucial matters such as peace, security, and membership require a two-thirds majority.

The Assembly meets annually, elects a new president each year, and conducts a general debate at the start of each session. Much of its work is handled by six main committees: Disarmament and Security, Economic and Financial, Social and Humanitarian, Special Political and Decolonization, Administrative and Budgetary, and Legal.

Over time, the Assembly has addressed major issues such as decolonization, apartheid in South Africa, terrorism, and the AIDS epidemic, passing hundreds of resolutions annually.

Although divisions—especially during the Cold War, the Arab-Israeli conflict, and debates on human rights—have limited consensus, the Assembly has been vital in shaping international opinion and mobilizing action.

The growth in membership during the 1960s–70s led to regionally based voting blocs, reflecting both East-West rivalries and later North-South economic divisions between industrialized and developing nations. Issues like global inequality, nuclear proliferation, and support for Israel remain central in these debates.

Security Council

The Security Council holds primary responsibility for maintaining international peace and security. Initially composed of 11 members (5 permanent and 6 nonpermanent), its membership expanded in 1965 to 15, with 10 nonpermanent members elected for two-year terms by the General Assembly to ensure regional representation. The five permanent members (P-5) are the United States, United Kingdom, France, Russia (successor to the Soviet Union), and China (which replaced Taiwan in 1971).

Each member has one vote, and decisions on substantive matters require nine votes including the concurrence of all five permanent members, giving them veto power. The Council functions continuously, meeting in New York, and can authorize peacekeeping forces, sanctions, or even military action under the UN Charter (Article 39). During the Cold War, veto rivalries between the U.S. and the Soviet Union weakened its effectiveness. Since the late 1980s, however, its role has expanded, authorizing numerous peacekeeping missions. Still, disagreements—such as over the 2003 Iraq War—have sometimes undermined consensus.

Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)

The Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) is the UN's main forum for economic, social, humanitarian, and cultural issues. It coordinates the work of UN agencies, promotes human rights, and encourages global cooperation in areas such as health, education, development, and science. Originally composed of 18 members, ECOSOC was expanded to 54 members (by amendments in 1965 and 1974), elected by the General Assembly for three-year terms. Its work is carried out through functional commissions (e.g., human rights, status of women,

narcotics, social development, population, science and technology) and regional commissions (Africa, Asia-Pacific, Latin America, Western Asia, and Europe).

ECOSOC also engages with nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) by granting consultative status, enabling them to participate in discussions and contribute reports. By the early 21st century, more than 2,500 NGOs had obtained such status.

Trusteeship Council

The Trusteeship Council was established to oversee territories placed under UN trusteeship after World War II, guiding them toward self-government or independence. These territories, mostly former League of Nations mandates, were administered by designated states under international supervision. The council included states administering trust territories, permanent members of the Security Council not administering territories, and other members elected by the General Assembly. It reviewed petitions, sent missions, and reported annually. With the independence of Palau in 1994, the last trust territory, the Trusteeship Council formally ended its operations. Although inactive, it may reconvene if needed, and proposals have been made to assign it new roles, such as managing global commons (e.g., outer space, the seabed) or serving as a forum for indigenous and minority rights.

International Court of Justice (ICJ)

The International Court of Justice (ICJ), often referred to as the World Court, serves as the UN's main judicial body. Its origins precede the UN, tracing back to the 1899 Hague Peace Conference, which first proposed an international court for resolving disputes. This idea later materialized as the Permanent Court of International Justice (PCIJ) under the League of Nations in 1919, and the ICJ replaced it with the establishment of the United Nations in 1945. The ICJ issues binding judgments and has wide jurisdiction, covering any disputes submitted to it by states as well as matters specified in the UN Charter, treaties, or conventions. However, a state cannot be brought before the Court without its consent, unless it has accepted compulsory jurisdiction for certain categories of disputes. The Court also provides advisory opinions at the request of the General Assembly, the Security Council, or other authorized UN organs and specialized agencies.

Although the ICJ has successfully settled some disputes—such as the 1992 Honduras–El Salvador border conflict—its influence is limited because many governments hesitate to

submit politically sensitive cases. At times, states have outright rejected the Court's authority or rulings. For instance, when Nicaragua sued the United States in 1984 over the mining of its harbors, the Court ruled in favor of Nicaragua. The U.S., however, refused to accept the decision, blocked Nicaragua's appeal in the Security Council, and withdrew from the Court's compulsory jurisdiction, which it had recognized since 1946.

The Court is composed of 15 judges, chosen independently by both the General Assembly and the Security Council. Judges serve nine-year terms with the possibility of re-election, and no two judges may come from the same country. They are selected to reflect the world's major legal systems. The ICJ is headquartered at The Hague, Netherlands. Here is the rephrased version of the Secretariat and Subsidiary Organs sections in the same style as the ICJ one:

Secretariat

The Secretariat is the United Nations' administrative and executive arm, responsible for carrying out the day-to-day operations mandated by the other principal organs. It prepares reports, conducts studies, provides research and documentation, and ensures the smooth functioning of UN programs. Unlike the political bodies, the Secretariat does not set policies but implements them. At its head is the Secretary-General, who serves as the chief administrative officer of the UN. Appointed by the General Assembly upon the recommendation of the Security Council, the Secretary-General plays a dual role: managing the UN's vast bureaucracy and acting as a global spokesperson and mediator in matters of international peace, security, and human rights. The office symbolizes the UN's independent voice, often taking initiatives in conflict resolution and humanitarian response.

The Secretariat's staff, drawn from across the world, is expected to act in the service of the UN as an impartial civil service, rather than representing national governments. Through its various departments, the Secretariat supports peacekeeping operations, coordinates humanitarian aid, oversees disarmament initiatives, addresses climate change, and facilitates sustainable development goals.

Subsidiary Organs

In addition to its six principal organs, the United Nations has established a wide range of subsidiary organs to address specific tasks. These bodies may be standing committees, commissions, councils, working groups, or ad hoc arrangements created to respond to

emerging challenges. Some of the most notable subsidiary organs include the Human Rights Council, which promotes and protects fundamental freedoms; the Commission on the Status of Women, which advocates for gender equality; and the Peacebuilding Commission, which supports countries emerging from conflict. Other specialized agencies, funds, and programs—such as UNICEF, UNDP, and UNEP—while not principal organs, are often closely linked to the UN system and function as extensions of its mission.

These subsidiary organs enable the UN to operate with greater flexibility, address technical and humanitarian concerns, and bring expert knowledge to global issues. They reflect the organization's evolving role in responding to the complex political, social, and economic challenges of the international community.

Specialized agencies

The specialized agencies report annually to ECOSOC and often cooperate with each other and with various UN organs. However, they also have their own principles, goals, and rules, which at times may conflict with those of other UN organs and agencies. The specialized agencies are autonomous insofar as they control their own budgets and have their own boards of directors, who appoint agency heads independently of the General Assembly or secretary-general. Major specialized agencies and related organs of the UN include the International Labour Organisation (ILO), the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO), the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO), and the World Health Organization (WHO). Two of the most powerful specialized agencies, which also are the most independent with respect to UN decision making, are the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund (IMF). The United Nations, along with its specialized agencies, is often referred to collectively as the United Nations system.

An Agenda for Peace (1992)

In June 1992, then United Nations Secretary-General Boutros Boutros-Ghali presented the landmark document “*An Agenda for Peace: Preventive Diplomacy, Peacemaking and Peacekeeping*” to the UN Security Council and the General Assembly. This was a critical moment in world politics, as the Cold War had recently ended, leading to a transformation in global power dynamics and opening up new possibilities for collective security. The document sought to outline a comprehensive framework for strengthening the UN’s role in maintaining international peace and security in the new era of international relations. The *Agenda for Peace* emphasized the need to expand and refine the UN’s operational tools for conflict management. It identified four core activities that could be systematically developed: *preventive diplomacy, peacemaking, peacekeeping, and post-conflict peacebuilding*. Preventive diplomacy referred to efforts aimed at preventing disputes from escalating into conflicts. Peacemaking involved diplomatic and political strategies to resolve disputes through negotiation, mediation, and reconciliation. Peacekeeping was redefined beyond traditional ceasefire monitoring to include more complex, multidimensional operations that support the implementation of peace agreements. Post-conflict peacebuilding was introduced as a new and essential dimension, focusing on rebuilding political, social, and economic structures in war-torn societies to prevent the recurrence of violence.

A distinctive feature of the report was its recognition that peace could not be sustained by political agreements alone; rather, it required addressing the root causes of conflict, including poverty, inequality, underdevelopment, and human rights violations. Boutros-Ghali emphasized that peace, development, and democracy were deeply interconnected and mutually reinforcing. Thus, the *Agenda for Peace* broadened the understanding of security from a purely military concept to one that included political, social, and economic dimensions. Another important aspect of the *Agenda for Peace* was its call for enhanced international cooperation and burden-sharing. It stressed that the UN alone could not bear the responsibility of conflict management and therefore encouraged stronger collaboration with regional organizations, non-governmental organizations, and civil society. This opened the way for a more decentralized and participatory approach to peace operations. The report also underlined the necessity of adequate funding, rapid deployment capabilities, and logistical support to make UN peace operations effective and credible.

While the *Agenda for Peace* was hailed as a visionary and comprehensive framework, its implementation faced challenges. The UN's peacekeeping operations in the 1990s, particularly in Somalia, Rwanda, and the Balkans, exposed the limitations of political will, resources, and coordination within the international system. Nevertheless, the report remains a foundational text in the evolution of peace and conflict studies, influencing later reforms and debates about the UN's role in peacebuilding and global governance. The 1992 UN Agenda for Peace marked a paradigm shift in the approach to international peace and security. By introducing preventive diplomacy and post-conflict peacebuilding as integral components, it reshaped the UN's vision of conflict management and underscored the importance of addressing both the immediate and structural causes of conflict. Though not without its shortcomings, the document remains a milestone in the history of international peace efforts, embodying the hope that the post-Cold War world could be more cooperative, inclusive, and peaceful.

Sustaining Peace

Sustaining peace seeks to prevent the emergence, escalation, persistence, and recurrence of conflict by addressing its underlying causes. It focuses on supporting parties in ending hostilities, fostering national reconciliation, and guiding societies toward recovery, reconstruction, and long-term development.

Sustaining Peace Resolutions (2016)

In April 2016, the UN General Assembly and the Security Council adopted two landmark resolutions on peacebuilding: A/RES/70/262 and S/RES/2282. These resolutions—often referred to as the Sustaining Peace Resolutions—emerged as a response to three major 2015 reviews on UN peace operations, peacebuilding structures, and the women, peace, and security agenda.

A key breakthrough was the recognition that peace efforts should not begin only after conflict erupts, but must also focus on preventing its outbreak, escalation, continuation, and recurrence. The idea of sustaining peace thus goes beyond traditional post-conflict peacebuilding, highlighting the importance of addressing root causes and reinforcing systems, institutions, and social mechanisms that support peace before violence occurs. In this way, the

resolutions repositioned the UN's approach to peace and security, encouraging more proactive and preventive measures. The resolutions stress that sustaining peace is a shared responsibility. While national governments and authorities hold the primary role in shaping priorities and strategies, closer partnerships between states, the UN, and other stakeholders are essential. They further emphasize the critical role of women's leadership and participation in conflict prevention and resolution, and call for greater inclusion of young people in sustaining peace efforts.

Operationalizing Sustaining Peace

UN Secretary-General António Guterres has placed prevention at the heart of sustaining peace, recognizing that lasting peace requires more than short-term post-conflict recovery. It involves addressing structural drivers of conflict, such as exclusion, inequality, corruption, and injustice.

In his 2018 *Report on Peacebuilding and Sustaining Peace* (A/72/707–S/2018/43), Guterres highlighted the need for stronger UN policy and operational coherence and stressed that sustaining peace depends on an ecosystem of partners working together in support of governments. The report prioritizes national ownership, urging support for local actors to build the capacities required to tackle social divisions and inequalities. Joint analysis and coordinated strategic planning across the UN system were identified as critical tools for advancing this agenda.

As Guterres noted, *“Sustaining peace will only be realized through committed, inclusive national ownership that considers the needs of the most marginalized, including women, young people, minorities, and people with disabilities.”*

The approach unfolds along three dimensions:

1. National and local ownership – shifting the primary responsibility for sustaining peace from international actors to national and community levels.
2. System-wide UN responsibility – leveraging the UN's three main pillars—peace and security, development, and human rights—together with humanitarian efforts, to achieve coherence.
3. Preventive focus – moving away from reactive responses to crises and instead investing in proactive measures to address risks before they escalate into violent conflict.

Through ongoing reforms in management, peace and security, and development, the Secretary-General has committed to establishing the leadership, planning, coordination, and funding mechanisms required to ensure a whole-of-UN approach to sustaining peace.

Linkages to the SDGs

The vision of sustaining peace is closely aligned with the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and its 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). The universality of Agenda 2030, its emphasis on prevention, and its pledge to “leave no one behind” directly reinforce the sustaining peace framework. SDG 16—which focuses on building peaceful, just, and inclusive societies—contains 12 targets that contribute directly to sustaining peace. These include promoting rule of law and access to justice, reducing corruption, strengthening accountable institutions, and ensuring access to information. However, the relevance of the SDGs to sustaining peace extends beyond Goal 16: the agenda’s broader emphasis on inclusion, equity, and rights-based development is essential to addressing the root causes of conflict.

Thus, sustaining peace and the SDGs are mutually reinforcing—peace is both a prerequisite for, and an outcome of, sustainable development.

Gandhian techniques of Conflict Resolution

Mahatma Gandhi

Mahatma Gandhi (October 2, 1869, Porbandar, India – January 30, 1948, Delhi) was an Indian lawyer, political leader, social reformer, and writer who emerged as the foremost figure in the Indian freedom struggle against British colonial rule. He is remembered as the “*Father of the Nation*” and is globally revered for developing and practicing the philosophy of *satyagraha*—a doctrine of nonviolent resistance for achieving social and political change.

To millions of Indians, he was the *Mahatma* (“Great Soul”). Everywhere he travelled, people gathered in vast numbers, often making his journeys emotionally and physically taxing. Reflecting on this, Gandhi himself once observed, “*The woes of the Mahatmas are known only to the Mahatmas.*” His influence extended beyond India, earning him worldwide recognition during his lifetime—a legacy that only deepened after his death, making “Mahatma Gandhi” one of the most universally recognized names across the globe.

Satyagraha: What is Satyagraha?

Satyagraha (pronounced *sat-yah-graha*) is derived from two Sanskrit words—*satya* (truth) and *agraha* (firm grasp, steadfastness). Literally, it means “holding firmly to truth” or “devotion to truth.” Gandhi conceptualized Satyagraha as the moral force of resisting injustice without resorting to violence. It was both a spiritual discipline and a practical method of political action. Gandhi believed that truth (*satya*) could only be realized through nonviolence (*ahimsa*), which he understood as “love in action” (Dalton, 1993). According to Michael Nagler (2004), Satyagraha is best described as “clinging to truth,” a view Gandhi shared in his writings. He argued that conflicts should not be seen as win/lose struggles because at the core, all human beings share common needs for peace, unity, and dignity. Martin Luther King Jr., influenced by Gandhi, referred to this philosophy as “love in action,” while Gene Sharp (1973) simplified it as “Gandhian nonviolence.” Together, these interpretations highlight that Satyagraha is not merely a political strategy but a radical moral philosophy with global resonance.

Gandhi's View of Satyagraha

For Gandhi, Satyagraha was not a predesigned plan but an outcome of life experiences and spiritual practice. His vow of *brahmacharya* (celibacy and self-restraint) in 1906, during his stay in South Africa, was central to his preparation for Satyagraha (Parekh, 1997). He described this vow as a form of self-purification, enabling him to confront injustice with inner strength. Reflecting on this, Gandhi wrote that “all the principal events of my life, culminating in the vow of Bramacharya, were secretly preparing me for it” (*Autobiography: The Story of My Experiments with Truth*, 1927).

Satyagraha, therefore, was not just a political tool but a spiritual discipline aimed at transforming both the oppressor and the oppressed. It rested on Gandhi's conviction that enduring suffering willingly could appeal to the conscience of the adversary and lead to reconciliation rather than destruction.

The Three Pillars of Satyagraha

The practice of Satyagraha rests on three essential principles: *Satya* (truth), *Ahimsa* (nonviolence), and *Tapasya* (self-suffering). Gandhi referred to these as the “pillars of Satyagraha” (Iyer, 1973).

- Truth (Satya): It requires honesty, transparency, and fairness in words and actions. For Gandhi, truth was not merely factual accuracy but alignment with a higher moral reality.
- Nonviolence (Ahimsa): Gandhi saw nonviolence not as passive submission but as active love and respect for all living beings. It rejects physical harm, hatred, and exploitation.
- Self-suffering (Tapasya): The willingness to endure hardship and sacrifice was central to Gandhi's approach. Rather than inflicting pain on others, the Satyagrahi bore suffering as a means of moral persuasion (Bondurant, 1965).

Unlike passive resistance, which may rely on expediency or weakness, Satyagraha was rooted in strength, discipline, and moral courage.

Qualities of a Satyagrahi

Gandhi recognized that practicing Satyagraha required personal discipline and training. He established Satyagraha Ashrams where volunteers were prepared for campaigns of nonviolent resistance. In these ashrams, strict rules of conduct were observed (Gandhi, 1927/1993).

A Satyagrahi had to maintain an unwavering faith in God or a higher moral truth. They were expected to uphold nonviolence and truth as guiding principles, live simply, and practice chastity. They were also required to abstain from intoxicants and material excesses to remain disciplined and focused. If imprisoned, a Satyagrahi was to follow jail rules unless those rules undermined human dignity. Most importantly, they had to willingly accept suffering and sacrifice, not as defeat but as a way of transforming injustice and appealing to the conscience of the oppressor. Gandhi insisted that only individuals who embodied these qualities could carry forward the movement of nonviolence effectively. In his view, the strength of a Satyagrahi lay not in physical force but in moral courage and spiritual resilience.

In summary, Satyagraha was Gandhi's greatest contribution to political and ethical thought. It combined truth, nonviolence, and self-discipline into a philosophy that transformed the fight against oppression into a moral endeavour. Gandhi demonstrated its power during campaigns in South Africa and India, proving that peaceful resistance could challenge even the mightiest empires. His influence extended far beyond India, shaping civil rights movements led by figures such as Martin Luther King Jr. in the United States and Nelson Mandela in South Africa. At its core, Satyagraha affirms that genuine justice cannot be achieved through violence and domination but only through steadfast adherence to truth, love, and moral courage. It remains one of the most powerful philosophies of social and political transformation in modern history.

M.K. Gandhi's Concepts of Truth, God, and Non-Violence

Whenever Mahatma Gandhi is remembered, the two ideals most closely associated with him are *Truth* and *Non-Violence*. Gandhi regarded these not merely as ethical principles but as the very foundations of his life and philosophy. For him, they were of supreme value, irrespective of personal or political costs, and became the guiding tools in India's struggle for independence.

Truth and God

Truthfulness, Gandhi emphasized, was the central feature of both thought and conduct. He derived the concept of *Satya* (Truth) from *Sat* meaning “being,” asserting that nothing exists except Truth. He equated Truth with God, later refining his belief from “God is Truth” to “Truth is God.” In his view, Truth represents ultimate reality—something even an atheist cannot deny, unlike belief in God. Gandhi described God as *Sat-Chit-Ananda*—Truth, Knowledge, and Bliss—highlighting the inseparability of these aspects. Thus, Truth was not only metaphysical but also spiritual, shaping human knowledge, morality, and joy.

The Philosophy of Non-Violence

Non-Violence (*Ahimsa*) for Gandhi implied complete selflessness and active love, not passive submission. He interpreted *Ahimsa* as “the greatest love and charity,” extending beyond humans to encompass all living beings. Non-Violence, therefore, meant refraining from harm in thought, word, and deed, while positively cultivating compassion, forgiveness, and goodwill. Gandhi stressed that non-violence was a higher value than life itself and considered it the universal law of humanity, as opposed to violence, which he described as the law of the brute. Gandhi viewed Non-Violence as dynamic action rather than inaction—resisting injustice through moral courage and suffering rather than retaliation. It was not cowardly avoidance of conflict but the pursuit of justice without hatred. He called it “dharma in action” and “truth translated,” emphasizing that it evolves as a creative moral force. For him, *Ahimsa* was inseparable from *Satya*, since Non-Violence was the means and Truth the end.

Interrelation of Truth and Non-Violence

Gandhi maintained that Truth and Non-Violence were like two sides of the same coin, impossible to separate. Without the practice of Non-Violence, Truth could not be realized, for God (as Truth) pervades all beings, and unity among them can only be achieved through love. Non-Violence, therefore, became the cementing bond of the universe. Although Gandhi acknowledged that absolute non-violence was unattainable in practice—since life itself involves some degree of violence—he insisted that humanity must strive toward it as an ideal. For him, *Ahimsa* was essentially love, a unifying energy that purifies the inner self and manifests in virtues such as kindness, generosity, and tolerance.

Enduring Relevance

Gandhi's philosophy demonstrates that while violence may arise out of anger, hatred, or selfishness, non-violence represents the higher law of human existence. By linking Truth with God and God with Love, Gandhi constructed a moral framework where spiritual realization and social transformation go hand in hand. His vision of Truth and Non-Violence continues to hold relevance in the 21st century as humanity grapples with injustice, conflict, and the search for peace.

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Gandhian Techniques of Conflict Resolution

Mahatma Gandhi's philosophy of conflict resolution represents one of the most profound contributions to political thought and peace practice in the twentieth century. Rooted in the twin principles of *Satya* (Truth) and *Ahimsa* (Non-Violence), Gandhi viewed conflict not as an abnormal condition but as an inevitable part of human interaction. However, instead of approaching conflict through coercion, aggression, or compromise alone, he proposed a moral and spiritual framework that emphasized reconciliation, justice, and human dignity. Gandhi's methods were not confined to abstract ideals; they were tested in practical struggles—ranging from his campaigns in South Africa against racial discrimination to India's freedom struggle against British colonialism. His approach combined ethical conviction with pragmatic strategies,

making it both principled and effective. Gandhi's methods—*Satyagraha*, non-cooperation, civil disobedience, constructive programme, dialogue, and voluntary suffering—demonstrate how nonviolent approaches can transform conflicts from destructive confrontation to cooperative problem-solving.

Satyagraha: The Moral Force of Truth

At the core of Gandhi's conflict resolution philosophy was *Satyagraha*, meaning "holding firmly to truth." For Gandhi, truth was not simply factual accuracy but ultimate reality and moral rightness. *Satyagraha* was therefore an insistence on discovering and adhering to truth, even in the face of adversity. Gandhi distinguished *Satyagraha* from passive resistance; while the latter could involve expediency or even hidden violence, *Satyagraha* was grounded in love and nonviolence. A *Satyagrahi*, or practitioner of *Satyagraha*, was expected to endure suffering voluntarily, never retaliate with violence, and remain open to dialogue with the adversary. A practical example of *Satyagraha* can be seen in Gandhi's leadership of the 1913 miners' strike in South Africa. Indian indentured workers, subjected to discriminatory taxation and denial of marriage recognition, undertook nonviolent marches under Gandhi's leadership. Despite arrests and hardships, the movement compelled the government to negotiate, ultimately abolishing the £3 tax and legally recognizing Indian marriages. This episode illustrates the central premise of *Satyagraha*: that moral persistence and collective suffering can awaken the conscience of the oppressor and resolve conflicts without violence (Parekh, 1997).

Non-Cooperation and Civil Disobedience

Gandhi's techniques of *Non-Cooperation* and *Civil Disobedience* were practical applications of *Satyagraha* in the Indian context. Non-Cooperation meant a deliberate withdrawal of support from unjust systems—be it economic, educational, or political. Gandhi argued that oppressive power relies on the consent of the governed, and by withdrawing this consent, citizens could undermine the legitimacy of unjust rule. The Non-Cooperation Movement (1920–22) mobilized millions of Indians to boycott British institutions, law courts, schools, and foreign goods. Although suspended after the outbreak of violence at Chauri Chaura, the movement demonstrated the potential of mass nonviolent mobilization to destabilize colonial authority.

Civil Disobedience, on the other hand, involved the deliberate and open violation of unjust laws, undertaken non-violently and with a willingness to accept punishment. Gandhi's Salt March of

1930 remains one of the most iconic acts of civil disobedience in history. By marching 240 miles to Dandi and producing salt in defiance of British monopoly laws, Gandhi transformed a basic commodity into a symbol of national resistance. The Salt March mobilized diverse sections of Indian society, drew global media attention, and forced the British to negotiate with Indian leaders at the Round Table Conference (Dalton, 1993). These movements exemplify how Gandhi's methods transformed structural conflicts into moral struggles, shifting the balance of power without resorting to violence.

Dialogue, Negotiation, and Persuasion

Unlike many revolutionary leaders, Gandhi never saw the opponent as an enemy to be destroyed but as a potential partner in the search for truth. He believed that dialogue and negotiation were central to conflict resolution, provided they were conducted in a spirit of sincerity and mutual respect. Gandhi frequently engaged in talks with colonial authorities, social reformers, and even political rivals. His negotiations with the Viceroy, Lord Irwin, which culminated in the Gandhi-Irwin Pact of 1931, are an example of how he combined mass resistance with dialogue. While Gandhi had mobilized nationwide civil disobedience through the Salt March, he was equally willing to enter negotiations to secure concessions for Indians, including the release of political prisoners and the right to make salt.

This approach demonstrated that nonviolent resistance was not merely confrontational but also reconciliatory. Gandhi argued that genuine negotiation must aim at a win-win outcome rather than victory for one side and humiliation for the other. He saw persuasion, rather than coercion, as the moral method of changing minds and hearts. Gandhi's practice of dialogue reflects a key principle of conflict resolution today: that sustainable peace arises not from domination but from recognition of mutual dignity and shared interests.

Constructive Programme: Addressing Root Causes

One of Gandhi's most innovative contributions to conflict resolution was his *Constructive Programme*, which sought to address the root causes of social conflict. Gandhi understood that structural inequalities—such as poverty, untouchability, illiteracy, and communal divisions—were fertile ground for conflict. Therefore, he promoted a set of social and economic reforms aimed at building self-reliant, just, and harmonious communities. The promotion of *khadi* (homespun cloth), village industries, literacy campaigns, and sanitation were not mere symbols

of resistance but practical steps toward reducing dependency on colonial systems. Gandhi also worked actively against untouchability, establishing the Harijan Sevak Sangh (1932) to promote social inclusion and dignity for marginalized communities. By addressing such structural injustices, Gandhi's constructive programme sought not only to resist colonial exploitation but also to prevent internal conflicts within Indian society. This aspect of his philosophy highlights that conflict resolution must go beyond managing disputes to transforming the socio-economic conditions that generate them.

Voluntary Suffering as Conflict Transformation

Perhaps the most distinctive Gandhian technique was his emphasis on voluntary suffering, or *tapasya*. Gandhi believed that self-suffering had a transformative moral power that violence could never achieve. By willingly enduring hardship, the Satyagrahi demonstrated sincerity and appealed to the conscience of the adversary. For Gandhi, this was not a tactic of weakness but a conscious choice of moral strength. An important case was Gandhi's fast in 1932 against separate electorates for Dalits, proposed under the Communal Award. While B.R. Ambedkar initially supported separate electorates as a safeguard for Dalit rights, Gandhi argued that it would divide Hindu society permanently. His fast unto death created enormous moral pressure, ultimately leading to the Poona Pact, which provided reserved seats for Dalits within the general electorate instead. This episode exemplifies Gandhi's belief that voluntary suffering could serve as a catalyst for negotiation and reconciliation, turning potentially divisive conflicts into opportunities for compromise (Guha, 2018).

Global Adaptations of Gandhian Methods

The influence of Gandhian conflict resolution techniques extended far beyond India. Martin Luther King Jr. in the United States explicitly drew upon Gandhi's philosophy in the Civil Rights Movement. The Montgomery Bus Boycott (1955–56) and the March on Washington (1963) were inspired by Gandhian principles of nonviolent protest, seeking not the humiliation of white Americans but the transformation of race relations through moral appeal (King, 1958). Similarly, Nelson Mandela and the African National Congress in South Africa integrated Gandhian strategies of boycott, non-cooperation, and dialogue in their struggle against apartheid, particularly during the 1980s. More recently, movements in Eastern Europe during the 1989 revolutions and even aspects of the Arab Spring have cited Gandhian principles of mass nonviolent resistance as inspiration (Sharp, 2012). These examples demonstrate that Gandhi's

methods are not bound to a particular culture or era but represent a universal model of conflict resolution applicable in diverse contexts.

Conclusion

Gandhi's techniques of conflict resolution offer a comprehensive framework that blends ethical conviction with practical strategies. Through Satyagraha, non-cooperation, civil disobedience, dialogue, constructive reform, and voluntary suffering, Gandhi demonstrated that conflict could be transformed into a process of moral awakening rather than destruction. Practical cases such as the 1913 miners' strike in South Africa, the Salt March of 1930, the Poona Pact of 1932, and the Harijan campaign against untouchability illustrate the effectiveness of his methods. The adoption of Gandhian techniques by leaders such as Martin Luther King Jr. and Nelson Mandela further validates their global relevance.

In contemporary times, marked by violent conflicts, ethnic divisions, and social inequalities, Gandhi's approach offers not only a historical model but also a timeless lesson: that peace is not merely the absence of violence but the presence of justice, reconciliation, and truth. Gandhi's legacy continues to shape modern peacebuilding efforts, affirming that nonviolence is not a passive stance but an active and transformative force in conflict resolution.

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Gandhian Model of Nonviolent Communication

Nonviolent Communication (NVC) represents a comprehensive approach to communication that emphasizes the interconnectedness of all forms of life. It extends beyond interpersonal exchanges to include how we communicate with ourselves, with society, with nature, and with other living beings. The fundamental idea behind NVC is that whenever communication becomes dysfunctional—whether through negative self-talk, harmful interactions with others, or exploitative communication with society, nature, or animals—it inevitably disrupts relationships and leads to conflict and disharmony (Kundu, 2022).

Exploring different perspectives on NVC, Kundu (2020) draws attention to the pluralistic traditions of Indian philosophy, which recognize communication as an inclusive process beginning with human thought itself. Thought, in this view, is not just private cognition but also the most basic form of communication, shaping the way humans relate to themselves and others. A significant feature of NVC is its encouragement to perceive ideas from multiple viewpoints. This resonates with the Jain philosophical doctrine of *anekantavada*—the principle of many-sidedness or relative pluralism. *Anekantavada* highlights the importance of embracing a multiplicity of perspectives, thus promoting tolerance and pluralism within the communication process. By recognizing the partial truth in different viewpoints, individuals can communicate with empathy and openness (Kundu, 2020). NVC also has a strong foundation in Buddhist traditions. Within the Eightfold Path prescribed by the Buddha, *samma-vaca* or “right speech” is central. The Buddha’s first discourse, the *Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta* (The Turning of the Wheel of Truth), identifies right speech as a necessary element of ethical living. The *Magga-Vibhanga Sutta* (SN 45:8) elaborates on this by defining right speech as abstaining from falsehood, divisive speech, abusive words, and idle gossip. Thus, Buddhist teachings underline how speech, when rooted in compassion and truth, becomes a powerful instrument of nonviolence.

In the modern context, American psychologist Marshall Rosenberg expanded the understanding of NVC by providing a practical framework. Rosenberg (2015) explains that NVC equips individuals with the skills to maintain their humanity even in challenging circumstances. Through NVC, individuals learn to reframe how they express themselves and how they listen to others. This shift in communication allows people to recognize not only their own deeper needs but also the needs of others, thereby nurturing healthier and more empathetic relationships.

Against the backdrop of these diverse approaches, the Gandhian model of NVC stands out as uniquely relevant in today's world. Gandhi's philosophy of communication is crucial in an era characterized by toxic rhetoric, misinformation, stereotyping, and digital polarization. Gandhi saw nonviolent communication as a means of fostering truth, justice, and reconciliation in society, making his ideas particularly valuable for addressing contemporary challenges.

One of the earliest efforts to articulate a Gandhian theory of NVC came from Bode (1994). Drawing from Gandhi's life and philosophy, Bode identified four key elements of Gandhian communication: (1) nonviolent speech and action, (2) the maintenance of relationships and enrichment of personhood, (3) openness, and (4) flexibility. According to this framework, violent communication inevitably breeds harm, while nonviolent communication strengthens human relationships and enhances individual dignity. Gandhi envisioned communication as a tool to value human beings, foster friendships, and create lasting bonds (Bode, 1994). Bode further emphasized that Gandhi's communication practices were rooted in openness and transparency. For Gandhi, openness included free speech, freedom of the press, public discussions, and direct negotiation. He believed that communication should be a means of building relationships and fostering personhood at both the individual and global level. This orientation reveals how Gandhi's approach combined ethical principles with practical methods of engaging society.

Subsequent scholars, including Parekh (1997), expanded upon Gandhi's ideas to highlight the Cosmo centric foundations of his worldview. Gandhi saw the cosmos as an interdependent system, in which humans were not at the apex but part of an ever-widening circle encompassing nature, animals, and the entire universe. He argued that since all beings were interdependent, human societies must reject exploitation, domination, and inequality, and instead nurture values of truth, cooperation, solidarity, and service. Gandhi's Cosmo centric philosophy thus broadens NVC into a holistic communication system that bridges humans, nature, and the larger cosmos.

In line with this Cosmo centric approach, Gandhi also advocated for epistemological pluralism. Parekh (1997) explains that Gandhi encouraged societies to value diverse sources of knowledge, including reason, intuition, faith, emotions, and traditional wisdom. A truly nonviolent society, Gandhi argued, must encourage dialogue, and avoid privileging one mode of knowledge over others. This plurality fosters inclusivity and helps communities cope with the complexities of life.

Central to Gandhi's philosophy was the belief that violence is temporary in effect but permanently damaging. He noted: "I object to violence because when it appears to do good, the good is only temporary; the evil it does is permanent." Violent communication leaves lasting scars in relationships and undermines trust. Nonviolent communication, by contrast, is sustainable and restorative.

What distinguishes the Gandhian model from other theoretical frameworks is its action-oriented nature. Gandhi did not view communication as merely theoretical; he used it as a tool to inspire constructive work. His communication strategies motivated his followers to work directly with the poor and marginalized, particularly in village reconstruction. Gandhi urged volunteers to immerse themselves in the lives of peasants and workers, to share their struggles, and to make their problems their own. This practice-oriented approach made his communication dynamic, empathetic, and deeply persuasive. The principle of *Satyagraha* (truth-force) lies at the heart of Gandhi's model of NVC. For Gandhi, adversaries were never permanent enemies but potential friends. A *satyagrahi* (practitioner of satyagraha) was expected to avoid bitterness, adhere to truth, and engage opponents with empathy. Gandhi argued that conflict resolution required understanding the opponent's viewpoint and stepping into their shoes. As he wrote in *Young India* (1925), most misunderstandings in the world would disappear if people learned to see issues from the perspective of their adversaries. Empathy, therefore, became a cornerstone of Gandhian communication (Joseph, 2022).

Another vital element was Gandhi's use of nonviolent persuasion. Pelton (1974) highlighted that true persuasion in Gandhi's framework required honesty, transparency, and respect. Manipulative strategies—such as withholding information or appealing to prejudice—were incompatible with nonviolence. Similarly, Bondurant (1958) emphasized that education and nonviolent propaganda were integral to Gandhi's communication strategies. These methods aimed not to coerce but to create awareness, foster dialogue, and promote understanding. Gandhi's commitment to openness and negotiation further underscores his communication philosophy. He maintained correspondence with his opponents, including British colonial authorities, even during active resistance. His conciliatory approach combined respect for the law with an unwavering commitment to ethical principles, as seen in his famous statement before the Magistrate in Champaran. Gandhi's ability to persuade without hostility demonstrated the transformative potential of nonviolent communication.

In his journalistic endeavours, too, Gandhi practiced restraint and truthfulness. His writings in *Indian Opinion* and *Young India* were marked by deliberate self-control, avoiding exaggeration, anger, or inflammatory language. He saw journalism as both a training in self-discipline and a means of fostering dialogue. In today's climate of hate speech, misinformation, and digital polarization, Gandhi's emphasis on restraint and truth in communication is especially relevant (Joseph, 2022).

Ultimately, Gandhi's philosophy of NVC left a legacy. As Dr. Rajendra Prasad noted, Gandhi's words, spoken and written across six decades, inspired individuals, shaped a mass movement, and provided humanity with a timeless model of ethical communication. Gandhi demonstrated that communication rooted in nonviolence, empathy, openness, and truth has the power not only to resolve conflicts but also to transform societies.

Gandhian Nonviolent Communication (NVC) with Contemporary Applications

Nonviolent Communication (NVC) represents a comprehensive approach to human interaction that stresses the interconnection of all forms of life. It extends beyond interpersonal exchanges to include how we communicate with ourselves, society, nature, and all living beings. The central idea is that when communication becomes harmful—whether through self-destructive inner dialogue, hostile interactions with others, or exploitative ways of relating to nature and animals—it inevitably disrupts harmony and fosters conflict (Kundu, 2022). Gandhi's reinterpretation of NVC provides a framework that seeks not only to reduce harm but also to restore relationships and promote justice.

Pluralism and Multi-perspectivity in NVC

A distinctive feature of NVC is its openness to multiple perspectives, which resonates with the Jain doctrine of *anekantavada*—the principle of many-sidedness. This principle insists that reality cannot be captured from a single viewpoint; each perspective is partial, and embracing diversity of views cultivates tolerance (Kundu, 2020). Gandhi frequently drew upon this principle to manage communal conflicts in India, particularly between Hindus and Muslims. In contemporary practice, similar ideas can be seen in *citizens' assemblies* on climate change, such as the UK Climate Assembly (2020), where people from diverse backgrounds engaged in structured dialogue to arrive at collective decisions. By emphasizing empathy, listening, and

recognition of partial truths, such initiatives embody Gandhian pluralism in addressing divisive global issues like climate policy.

Buddhist Roots: Right Speech and NVC

The Buddhist emphasis on *samma-vaca* (right speech) also provides an ethical grounding for NVC. According to Buddhist teachings, right speech avoids lies, divisive words, abusive language, and idle gossip. Gandhi's practice of self-restraint in communication mirrors this principle, insisting that words should heal, not wound. In today's context, such guidance is vital for countering digital polarization and online hate speech. For example, initiatives like *Twitter's Birdwatch* (now "Community Notes") use collaborative fact-checking to counter misinformation, reflecting Gandhian ideals of collective truth-seeking. Similarly, digital literacy campaigns in India, such as *MediaBuddy*, train young people to detect fake news and resist toxic rhetoric, showcasing how Gandhian "right speech" can be adapted to contemporary communication crises.

Rosenberg's Modern Framework and Gandhi's Resonance

Marshall Rosenberg's model of NVC emphasizes reframing communication to uncover needs behind words and actions, enabling empathy and connection (Rosenberg, 2015). Gandhi anticipated this approach by framing adversaries not as enemies but as potential allies who must be understood in their full humanity. This is visible today in community peacebuilding initiatives such as *Search for Common Ground*, which uses dialogue and empathy-based communication in conflict zones like Nigeria and the Democratic Republic of Congo. These efforts echo Gandhian strategies: they humanize "the other," focus on unmet needs, and build bridges across deep divides without resorting to coercion.

Bode's Four Pillars of Gandhian NVC

Bode (1994) identified four components of Gandhian communication: (1) nonviolent speech and action, (2) relationship-building and personal enrichment, (3) openness, and (4) flexibility. These components can be observed in today's climate justice movements, such as *Fridays for Future* and *Extinction Rebellion*. Although Extinction Rebellion is known for its disruptive tactics, its emphasis on peaceful protest, openness in decision-making, and prioritizing relational ties within communities reflects Gandhian elements of communication. By refusing violent confrontation

and focusing on awakening moral conscience, such movements mirror Gandhi's techniques of persuasion and constructive dialogue.

Constructive Work and Sarvodaya in Practice

For Gandhi, communication was never detached from constructive work. His philosophy of *sarvodaya* (welfare of all) required activists to build equitable structures that reduce inequality and preempt conflict (Parekh, 1997). A contemporary example is India's *Self-Employed Women's Association (SEWA)*, which organizes women in the informal sector, fostering dignity and collective empowerment through communication rooted in solidarity (Chen, 2008). Internationally, initiatives like *Ubuntu Dialogues* in post-apartheid South Africa stress community dialogue for healing historical wounds, showing how Gandhian constructive communication continues to address systemic injustice.

Satyagraha in Contemporary Movements

The principle of *satyagraha*, or truth-force, lies at the heart of Gandhi's NVC. Gandhi insisted that conflicts should be addressed by appealing to the opponent's conscience rather than coercion. A clear modern example is the *Standing Rock protests* (2016–2017) in the United States, where Indigenous communities resisted the Dakota Access Pipeline through prayer, nonviolent gatherings, and cultural expression (Estes, 2019). Despite facing violence from state authorities, protestors held to nonviolence, echoing Gandhian *satyagraha*. In India, Anna Hazare's anti-corruption movement (2011) similarly used fasting as a nonviolent means to awaken political leaders' moral accountability, reinforcing Gandhi's idea of truth-centered struggle

Dialogue, Forgiveness, and Peacebuilding

Gandhi's reliance on dialogue and forgiveness as conflict resolution tools finds resonance in global reconciliation processes. The *Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC)* in South Africa, led by Desmond Tutu, emphasized forgiveness and empathy over vengeance (Tutu, 1999). Similarly, in post-genocide Rwanda, *Gacaca courts* relied on confessions, community dialogue, and restorative justice, aligning with Gandhian ideals (Clark, 2010). More recently, Colombia's peace process with FARC has incorporated community dialogues and truth-telling mechanisms, highlighting the ongoing relevance of Gandhian reconciliation methods in healing fractured societies (Rettberg, 2020).

Gandhi's Journalism and Digital Relevance

In his editorial work, Gandhi exemplified disciplined, truthful communication. His journals *Young India* and *Harijan* avoided inflammatory rhetoric, focusing instead on constructive dialogue. In today's era of misinformation and hate speech, this ethic is urgently needed. Projects like *AltNews* in India and *PolitiFact* in the U.S. echo this Gandhian journalism ethos by prioritizing fact-checking, transparency, and restraint. These initiatives demonstrate that digital communication rooted in truth and responsibility remains a cornerstone of democratic resilience.

Conclusion

Gandhi's philosophy of Nonviolent Communication continues to offer powerful tools for contemporary conflict resolution. Through principles such as pluralism, right speech, satyagraha, constructive action, and forgiveness, Gandhi demonstrated that communication could become an instrument of moral persuasion, social justice, and reconciliation. Contemporary movements—from Shaheen Bagh to Standing Rock, from climate assemblies to fact-checking networks—show that Gandhian communication is not confined to history but actively shapes today's struggles for peace, justice, and sustainability. In an age of polarization and ecological crisis, Gandhi's communicative ethics remain not just relevant but indispensable.

Nonviolent Communication: Marshall B. Rosenberg

Marshall B. Rosenberg's *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Life* (2019) provides a systematic framework for understanding how patterns of speech either foster human connection or perpetuate alienation and violence. In the chapter "Communication That Blocks Compassion," Rosenberg identifies recurring linguistic structures—such as moralistic judgments, comparisons, denial of responsibility, and demands—that inhibit authentic human relationships. He terms these *life-alienating forms of communication*, rooted historically in hierarchical and domination-based societies. This summary critically examines these concepts while situating them within both Indian and Western socio-cultural contexts.

Conceptual Foundations: Life-Alienating Communication

Rosenberg argues that conventional language often emphasizes rightness, wrongness, and blame. Such communication focuses attention on “who is what” rather than “what is needed.” The key dimensions include:

1. **Moralistic Judgments** – Labeling others as “lazy,” “selfish,” or “irresponsible” reflects projection of one’s unmet needs rather than engagement with the other’s humanity. Rosenberg views such analyses as *tragic expressions* of values, because they provoke defensiveness or compliance through fear, guilt, or shame.
2. **Comparisons** – Whether in family or institutional contexts, comparative judgments undermine self-worth and compassion. In Western culture, comparison with “ideal” figures (e.g., Mozart in childhood) fuels inadequacy, while in Indian society, frequent academic and career comparisons between peers and relatives reproduce anxiety and resentment.
3. **Denial of Responsibility** – Statements such as “I had to” or “They made me do it” obscure human agency. Historical examples, such as Nazi bureaucrats’ reliance on *Amtssprache* (bureaucratic language of obedience), illustrate how denial of responsibility facilitates systemic violence.
4. **Demands versus Requests** – Hierarchical institutions often employ demands, accompanied by implicit threats of punishment. Rosenberg emphasizes the importance of reframing demands into requests that acknowledge autonomy and invite collaboration.
5. **Domination Systems** – These linguistic patterns emerge historically in societies where elites sought to control populations. The prevalence of “should,” “must,” and “deserve” perpetuates external authority and compliance, undermining empathy and mutual respect.

Applications in the Indian Context

The Indian sociocultural landscape—marked by collectivism, familial obligations, and hierarchical traditions—presents distinct challenges and opportunities for NVC.

- **Family Structures:** Parents frequently exercise authority through demands, e.g., “You must pursue engineering.” An NVC reframing might be: “I feel anxious because I value financial security. Can we discuss your career interests alongside this concern?” Such language affirms parental needs while respecting the child’s autonomy.

- **Educational Practices:** Indian pedagogy has historically relied on authority and comparison (“Your cousin scored higher; you should do better”). NVC suggests reframing toward needs: “I feel concerned when assignments are incomplete because I value participation and growth in the classroom.”
- **Communal and Social Relations:** In interreligious or intercaste conflicts, judgments such as “they are wrong” perpetuate hostility. NVC instead emphasizes articulation of needs— “Our community feels fear because we seek safety and recognition”—which creates the possibility of reciprocal understanding and dialogue.

Applications in the Western Context

Western societies, while emphasizing individual autonomy, also manifest life-alienating communication in professional and political spheres.

- **Workplace and Corporate Culture:** Employees often claim, “I have to work overtime,” obscuring agency. An NVC reframing would state: “I choose to work late because I value job security, though I also need rest.” This linguistic shift increases awareness of both needs and choices.
- **Educational Settings:** Teachers who label students as “lazy” alienate learners. An NVC-oriented teacher might say: “When assignments are delayed, I feel frustrated because I value engagement and fairness.” This transformation preserves dignity while maintaining accountability.
- **Political Polarization:** Western political discourse often demonizes opponents as “evil” or “ignorant.” From an NVC perspective, such judgments obscure underlying needs, such as justice, security, or freedom. Reframing debates around values and needs could foster constructive dialogue in democratic institutions.

Critical Reflections

Rosenberg’s framework offers a radical critique of linguistic and cultural systems that normalize domination. In both Indian and Western contexts, NVC challenges entrenched patterns—whether parental authority in collectivist families or adversarial rhetoric in democratic politics. The emphasis on needs-based expression reveals the universality of human vulnerability while also accommodating cultural variation.

From an academic standpoint, NVC resonates with theories of peace studies, Gandhian nonviolence, and Habermasian communicative action. Gandhi's insistence on *ahimsa* (nonviolence) parallels Rosenberg's rejection of blame and punishment. Similarly, Jürgen Habermas' concept of "communicative rationality" aligns with NVC's focus on dialogue grounded in mutual recognition rather than strategic manipulation.

Conclusion

Nonviolent Communication provides both a practical methodology and a theoretical critique of language that alienates humans from compassion. Its application in India highlights the possibility of balancing tradition with autonomy, while in the West it offers tools for countering alienation and polarization. Ultimately, Rosenberg's contribution lies in redefining communication as a means of social transformation: from hierarchical obedience and judgment toward empathy, mutual recognition, and peace.

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Heartful Communication

Heartful Communication offers a new awareness, a heart-centred way of understanding and conversing with people, that combines principles and practices from Heartfulness and from Nonviolent Communication [an approach originating from Dr. Marshall B. Rosenberg]. It offers a tried and tested range of principles, practices and specific tools that can support us to move from judgment and criticism, to understanding each other more deeply, connecting with empathy and acting with compassion. HC enables clarity, balance and cooperative ways of living which are vital to our well-being. In this chapter we are going to explore few concepts and practices that can empower us to approach conflicts differently, by understanding others with the lens of ‘Needs’ awareness.

Needs Awareness

The Non-Violent Communication process developed by Marshall Rosenberg offers us a Needs centred approach to life. It encourages us to look beneath the actions and words of the other and try to sense into what is it that is motivating them or what is it that the other is longing for. It allows us to transform our judgements of others and understand them through the lens of ‘Needs’.

Needs are universal to all human beings. We all experience these energies that are alive within us and seek fulfillment at different points in our lives. Some of the needs may be stronger in some people than in others. But we all have probably experienced these needs at some point or situation in life, which is why they are ‘universal’ and ‘shared’.

Every action that we do, always has an underlying need beneath it. Marshall Rosenberg says “A Need is life seeking expression”.

A key to Heartful Communication is the idea that all human behaviour is motivated by these Human Values and Needs. This could bring a significant shift in our consciousness. We learn to see human behaviour in a different way, a reliable way that can help us even when we are under emotional pressure.

Needs and Strategies

The actions that individuals take to fulfill these needs are called 'strategies. For instance, someone might choose to jog every day to meet their need for Physical Fitness whereas someone else might choose to join a gym. Being aware of the difference between Needs and strategies is one of the key elements of this approach. It allows us to approach conflicts in a more peaceful way.

Approaching Conflict through Needs

Conflicts are always at the level of Strategies not Needs. Once we can connect to the need that is alive within a person, we can choose different ways to meet those needs. The important element to understand here is that Needs can be met in many ways. The concept of conflict resolution in HC encourages us to consider the needs of all parties involved in the conflict or disagreement. It offers a space where everyone can express their needs and feel heard by the others.

Feelings

Our feelings can help us to connect with our own needs and those of the others. Feelings arise when our needs are met or unmet. For instance, when my need for rest is not met, I might feel 'tired' and when my need for fun is met, I might feel 'joyful' or 'refreshed'. Our feelings arise from our met or unmet needs.

Feeling List:

Acceptance

Acknowledgment
Appreciation
Gratitude
Reassurance
Representation
Self-Acceptance
Self-Respect
Support
To Be Heard
To Be Known
To Be Met
To Be Seen
To Matter

Care

Affection
Closeness
Compassion
Consideration
Empathy
Intimacy
Love
Mutuality
Nurturing
Reciprocity
Self-Care

Connection

Belonging
Inclusion
Collaboration
Cooperation
Communication
Community
Companionship
Friendship
Interdependence
Participation
Partnership
Presence
Self-Connection
Shared Reality
Synergy
Trust

Awareness

Clarity
Consciousness
Discovery
Focus
Learning
Perspective
To Know
To See
Understanding

Meaning

Challenge
Communion
Competence
Contribution
Creativity
Depth
Diversity
Efficiency
Effectiveness
Engagement
Flow
Growth
Honesty
Inspiration
Integration
Integrity
Mourning
Progress
Purpose
Respect

Play

Adventure
Aliveness
Celebration
Excitement
Fun
Humor
Joy
Relaxation
Stimulation

Autonomy

Authenticity
Choice
Dignity
Freedom
Identity
Independence
Power (in Your World)
Security
Self-Expression
Space
Spontaneity

Peace

Balance
Beauty
Consistency
Ease
Equanimity
Faith
Harmony
Hope
Order
Peace of Mind
Stability

Physical Well-Being

Breath
Comfort
Exercise
Health
Hydration
Movement
Nutrition
Rest
Safety
Sexual Expression
Shelter
Touch
Warmth

FEELINGS WHEN NEEDS ARE FULFILLED

Beat
Burned-out
Depleted
Exhausted
Lethargic
Listless
Sleepy
Tired
Wiped-out
Worn-out